**Aquifer Open Study Notes**

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# 2 Samuel

## 2 Samuel 1:1

David returned from the slaughter: Before this, David and his men had killed many Amalekites because of what they had done to David's city and family (see 1 Samuel 30).

## 2 Samuel 1:1–16

An unnamed Amalekite went to David, claiming that he had killed Saul. This claim was false. Saul had taken his own life(1 Samuel 31:4–6).

The Amalekite may have hoped that David would reward him for clearing the way for David to become king. Instead, David ordered him to be killed for harming the Lord's anointed (the person God had chosen).

## 2 Samuel 1:1–27

The forty years of Saul's reign ended in tragedy. The Philistines struck a devastating blow against his people. They killed Saul's sons and later mutilated Saul's body after he took his own life (1 Samuel 31). After these tragic events, the story begins to focus on David and his rise as a leader.

## 2 Samuel 1:4

- What was the outcome?: David did not know about Saul's death because he was not involved in it.
- Saul and ... Jonathan are also dead: Two other sons of Saul, Abinadab and Malkishua, were killed as well (1 Samuel 31:2). The Amalekite may not have known that Saul's other sons had died. Or he mentioned only the son who could prevent David from ruling as king of Israel.

## 2 Samuel 1:6

"I happened to be on Mount Gilboa,": This is the Amalekite man's second lie. More likely, he searched the area after the battle. He was looking for soldiers whose valuables he could take.

## 2 Samuel 1:9

Then he begged me: This is the Amalekite's third lie. Saul was probably already dead (see 1 Samuel 31:4–6).

## 2 Samuel 1:10

- The Amalekite probably reached Saul's body before the Philistines did. The Philistines would not have left royal items, such as Saul's crown and armband, on his body.
- Israel's king wore a crown. The Hebrew word is nezer, which means "consecration" (being set apart for holy use). The crown showed that Saul was set apart to God and chosen as the Lord's anointed (2 Samuel 1:14).

## 2 Samuel 1:13

Where are you from?: David asks again (2 Samuel 1:8). He may have repeated the question because of the depth of his grief.

## 2 Samuel 1:15–16

The Amalekite expected a reward for killing David's rival but was instead condemned for killing the Lord's anointed. David himself had twice refused the opportunity to kill Saul (see 1 Samuel 24:5–7; 26:9–11).

## 2 Samuel 1:18

The Book of Jashar is an extrabiblical text (not included in the Bible) and is no longer available. It was probably an Israelite epic poem or a collection of poems. These poems likely described important events in Israel's history, including Joshua's conquest of Canaan (see Joshua 10:13) and the rise of David as king.

## 2 Samuel 1:19

Your glory: David's description focused more on Saul's royal position than on his personal characteristics.

## 2 Samuel 1:20

- Gath and Ashkelon were major Philistine cities. If people announced Saul's death there, the Philistines would have the chance to celebrate. They could boast over Israel and praise their god Dagon, while mocking Israel's God, Yahweh.
- daughters of the Philistines: In ancient war culture, young women sometimes celebrated victories with songs (see Exodus 15:20–21; 1 Samuel 18:7).

## 2 Samuel 1:21

- Saul and Jonathan died in the mountains of Gilboa (1 Samuel 31:1).
- may you have no dew or rain: David was calling down a curse on the place where they died. In the ancient Near East, people sometimes spoke curses like this to express deep grief. A Canaanite text from the 1300s BC records a father speaking a very similar curse over the place where his son died.
- The shield of Saul represents his military victories as king. It would no longer be anointed with oil. This matched the fact that Saul was no longer the Lord's anointed king, because he had died.

## 2 Samuel 1:22

From the blood of the slain: Saul and Jonathan were known as brave and successful warriors (see 1 Samuel 11:1–11; 14:1–23, 47–48). However, their military reputation did not equal that of David, who became famous for defeating Israel's enemies (1 Samuel 18:7; 21:11).

## 2 Samuel 1:23

beloved and delightful ... not divided in death: The relationship between Saul and Jonathan was often strained. This was especially true because of Saul's treatment of David (see 1 Samuel 20:30–33). Even so, Jonathan fought alongside his father and died with him while defending Israel against the Philistines.

## 2 Samuel 1:26

surpassing the love of women: Jonathan's loyalty and friendship with David involved great personal risk and sacrifice. This kind of commitment was stronger than any other relationship David described in his life, including the love he received from his wives. The phrase does not suggest a sexual relationship. Instead, it emphasizes deep loyalty and covenant friendship. The book of First Samuel highlights Jonathan's love for David three times in 1 Samuel (1 Samuel 18:1, 3; 20:17).

## 2 Samuel 2:1

- David asked the Lord for guidance (see 2 Samuel 5:23–24; Judges 1:1–2; 20:18; 1 Samuel 10:22). He did this by consulting the Urim and Thummim (see Exodus 28:30; Leviticus 8:8; Deuteronomy 33:8; 1 Samuel 14:41). Abiathar, David's priest, administered them (1 Samuel 23:1–12; 30:7–8). David acted only when God directed him. He did not act before receiving guidance.
- Hebron was about thirty kilometers (nineteen miles) southwest of Jerusalem. Abraham lived in this area for a time and later bought a nearby cave as a family burial place (Genesis 23). The people of this region supported David (see 1 Samuel 30:26–31).

## 2 Samuel 2:1–32

After Saul died, those loyal to David (the tribe of Judah) came into conflict with those loyal to Saul's son Ish-bosheth (the remaining tribes of Israel).

At this time, the Philistines controlled much of the land west of the Jordan River. They likely encouraged this division among the Israelites because a divided people were easier for them to control.

## 2 Samuel 2:2

Ahinoam: See study note on 1 Samuel 25:43. David's other wife, Michal, the daughter of Saul, had been given to another man after David fled from Saul (1 Samuel 25:44).

Abigail: See 1 Samuel 25.

## 2 Samuel 2:4–7

After David established his rule in Hebron, he showed kindness to people who were still loyal to Saul. This included the men of Jabesh-gilead. However, because they remained loyal to Saul and his family line, they did not accept David as king (2 Samuel 2:8–11). David also had friendly relations with Nahash, the king of the Ammonites (see 2 Samuel 10:2; 17:27–29). Nahash had earlier attacked Jabesh-gilead and caused great suffering there (1 Samuel 11:1–15).

## 2 Samuel 2:7

David became king because the people of Judah anointed him, which gave him a legal basis for his rule, just as it had for Saul (1 Samuel 11:15). Years earlier, the prophet Samuel had also anointed David, showing that God had chosen him to be king (1 Samuel 16:13).

## 2 Samuel 2:8

- Abner: See study note on 1 Samuel 20:25.
- Mahanaim was east of the Jordan River, high in the hills of Gilead, near a source of fresh water. Saul and his family had a close connection to the region of Gilead (1 Samuel 11:1–11; 31:11–13). Because Mahanaim was east of the Jordan River, Ish-bosheth's rule was harder for David's forces to attack. Later, King David also used this same area as a temporary place of safety after Absalom's rebellion (2 Samuel 17:24, 27).
- The name Ish-bosheth means "man of shame." His original name was Esh-baal, which means "man of Baal." Baal means "lord," "master," or "possessor," and was also the name of a Canaanite god worshiped by Israel's neighbors (see Numbers 25:3). Because of this association, Ish-bosheth's name was likely changed later to avoid using the name of a foreign god.

## 2 Samuel 2:9

Gilead was the easternmost district of the northern kingdom. Jezreel was the northernmost area, and Benjamin was the southernmost. Ephraim lay between them.

It is not clear where the land of the Ashurites was located. The phrase all Israel refers to the tribes that Ish-bosheth ruled over, not to the physical size or boundaries of his kingdom within Israel.

### 2 Samuel 2:10–11

Ish-bosheth ruled from Mahanaim for two years during David's seven-and-a-half-year reign from Hebron. This suggests that there was a gap of about five years when the northern tribes had no king.

### 2 Samuel 2:12

Gibeon, about eight kilometers (five miles) northwest of Jerusalem, was an important city in the region of Benjamin.

### 2 Samuel 2:12–32

A long civil war followed between Judah, led by David, and the northern tribes, led by Saul's family. These events led directly to the murder of Abner (2 Samuel 3:22–39).

### 2 Samuel 2:13

The pool of Gibeon goes down about 24 meters (80 feet) to reach the water table (the level underground where water collects). Archaeologists estimate that the original builders removed about 3,000 tons of limestone (about 2,700 metric tons) to make the pool.

### 2 Samuel 2:14

the young men: In ancient times, enemy armies sometimes picked individuals or small groups to fight as representative gladiators. This practice is often called champion warfare (see also 1 Samuel 17).

compete: The Hebrew term usually suggests an element of play. A contest of champions might have been seen as a high-stakes game. In this case, it resolved nothing. The fighting grew into a much larger battle with more casualties (2 Samuel 2:17–32).

### 2 Samuel 2:17

The number of people killed in this battle is recorded in 2 Samuel 2:30–31.

### 2 Samuel 2:18

Zeruiah was David's sister (1 Chronicles 2:15–16). So, Joab, Abishai, and Asahel were his nephews.

### 2 Samuel 2:20–22

Turn to your right or to your left ... Stop chasing me: Abner's words show respect between men trained for the same kind of military work, along with a desire for fairness in battle. Asahel, who was still young, would not have been able to defeat the more experienced Abner. Abner also understood that killing Asahel would worsen the conflict with David, and David's troops would try to take revenge (see 2 Samuel 3:22–39).

### 2 Samuel 2:24

- Joab and Abishai pursued Abner: See 2 Samuel 3:27.
- Ammah means "conduit" (a channel for carrying water), and Giah means "gushing." These names suggest that an aqueduct system (a structure that carries water) was connected to the pool at Gibeon (2 Samuel 2:12–13).

### 2 Samuel 2:26

this will only end in bitterness: Realizing that such wars go on generation after generation, Abner wisely negotiated a truce.

### 2 Samuel 2:28

The ram's horn signaled the beginning and end of combat (see also 2 Samuel 18:16; Joshua 6:15–16). For other uses of the ram's horn, see study note on 2 Samuel 6:15.

### 2 Samuel 2:29

Abner acted wisely by putting as much distance as possible between his troops and the forces of Joab. He understood that their desire for blood vengeance (revenge for a killing) could break the truce.

### 2 Samuel 2:31

The 360 men who died all belonged to the tribe of Benjamin, the tribe of Saul. They were fighting under the command of one of Saul's relatives. This defeat was a direct blow to Saul's family line and its claim to rule (compare 2 Samuel 3:1).

### 2 Samuel 3:1

the war ... was protracted: This civil war likely lasted for most of the more than seven years that David ruled from Hebron. The truce called by Joab and Abner did not last long (2 Samuel 2:26–28).

### 2 Samuel 3:1–39

The house of David (David's family line and those loyal to his rule) grew stronger, while the house of Saul grew weaker. A key turning point came when Abner, who held the real political power among Saul's followers, changed his loyalty to David. When Abner

did this, many of his relatives from the northern tribes followed him.

### 2 Samuel 3:2–5

David grew stronger and stronger (2 Samuel 3:1) by marrying more wives and having a son with each wife. Three of David's sons who were born in Hebron died violent deaths. Two died during David's reign (Amnon and Absalom), and one, Adonijah, died shortly after David's death.

### 2 Samuel 3:3

Geshur was a small Canaanite kingdom in upper Transjordan (the area east of the Jordan) near the Sea of Galilee. Marrying into neighboring royal families created political alliances and secured David's position against the northern tribes. Solomon also followed this practice (1 Kings 3:1; 11:1).

### 2 Samuel 3:7

- Why did you sleep with my father's concubine?: It is not clear whether Abner actually did this. Taking a king's wife or concubine was often a sign that someone was trying to take the king's place (that is, trying to become king; see 2 Samuel 12:8; 16:21; 1 Kings 2:17–25).
- Rizpah: See also 2 Samuel 21:8–14.

### 2 Samuel 3:8

- a dog that belongs to Judah: See 1 Samuel 17:43.
- have not delivered you into the hand of David: Abner had control over the life and death of Saul's son.

### 2 Samuel 3:9

do for David what the LORD has sworn to him: Abner was aware that God had chosen David to be king over all Israel (see also 2 Samuel 3:18).

### 2 Samuel 3:10

- transfer the kingdom ... David: Compare 1 Samuel 28:17.
- establish the throne of David: Whether as an ally or an enemy, Abner was a powerful man. In this moment, he speaks with authority, as if he is declaring God's decision rather than his own (see 2 Samuel 7:13).

### 2 Samuel 3:11

did not dare to say another word: Ish-bosheth's silence clearly shows his weakness as a ruler. Abner, who made Ish-bosheth king and supported his rule, held the real power during Ish-bosheth's reign (2 Samuel 2:8–9).

### 2 Samuel 3:12

In the proposed solemn pact (or covenant), Abner acknowledged that David would become king. Abner may have hoped to serve as David's chief leader under him (that is, second in authority).

### 2 Samuel 3:13

Saul had given his daughter Michal to David as his wife (1 Samuel 18:20–27). However, when Michal saved David's life from her father (1 Samuel 19:11–17), Saul ended the marriage and gave Michal to another man, Palti (1 Samuel 25:44). If David got her back now, it would strengthen his claim to Saul's kingdom (see 1 Kings 2:13–25).

### 2 Samuel 3:14

a hundred Philistine foreskins: Saul hoped that David would be killed while trying to pay the bride-price (the gift a man gave to a woman's family before marriage; see 1 Samuel 18:17–27).

### 2 Samuel 3:15

Ish-bosheth sent and took: Although Abner made the deal with David (2 Samuel 3:12–13), it was Ish-bosheth who gave Michal to David. This action shows Ishbosheth's weakness as a king and his fear of Abner (2 Samuel 3:11).

### 2 Samuel 3:16

- Palti wept deeply as this happened, but he had no power to stop it (compare Judges 18:1–26).
- Bahurim was likely a place where people supported Saul's family. It was located just east of Jerusalem (compare 2 Samuel 16:5).

### 2 Samuel 3:17

It seems that support among the elders of Israel in the north had been growing to accept David as king, even though the text has not mentioned this earlier.

### 2 Samuel 3:18

See also 2 Samuel 3:9. By freeing the people from the Philistines, David would do what Saul had failed to do (1 Samuel 9:16).

### 2 Samuel 3:19

Because Saul came from the tribe of Benjamin, the men of Benjamin likely saw David, who was from

Judah, as someone trying to take Saul's place as king. However, Abner was widely respected among Saul's followers. Because of this, Abner was able to gain support for David even within Saul's own tribe.

## 2 Samuel 3:21

- The narrator emphasized that David sent Abner safely on his way as a friend and an ally (restated in 2 Samuel 3:22–23). David was at peace with Abner and was not involved in the killing of this well-known military leader (see 2 Samuel 3:28–29).
- Despite Abner's murder (2 Samuel 3:27), the northern tribes later did make a covenant with David to make him their king, just as Abner had promised earlier (2 Samuel 5:1–3).

## 2 Samuel 3:26

- The exact location of the well of Sirah is unknown. It was likely near Hebron.
- David was unaware of it: See study note on 2 Samuel 3:21.

## 2 Samuel 3:27

- as if to speak to him privately: Joab accused Abner of acting with deception (2 Samuel 3:25). However, Joab himself used deception when he drew Abner aside in order to kill him.
- on account of the blood: Joab acted according to the custom of blood vengeance (the practice of killing the person who had killed a close family member).

## 2 Samuel 3:28

- David made it clear that he had no part in Abner's death and described it as a crime. David understood that because his second-in-command had killed Abner, people loyal to Saul's family might believe that David had ordered the killing.
- before the LORD: David called on the Lord to hold him accountable if he were lying.

## 2 Samuel 3:29

- skin disease: While leprosy is a possible translation, the Hebrew term here likely refers to many kinds of skin problems or rashes, not only Hansen's disease.
- who leans on a staff: This curse effectively separated Joab from David. From this point on, their relationship was only professional. David later ordered Solomon to deal with Joab before David died (1 Kings 2:5–6). Solomon's later statement clearing David of guilt in Abner's death (1 Kings 2:31–33) shows that David's mourning for Abner was sincere.

## 2 Samuel 3:30

See 2 Samuel 2:18–28.

## 2 Samuel 3:31

King David himself walked: David took part publicly in the mourning procession. He wept openly at the gravesite (2 Samuel 3:32) and later refused to eat as a sign of mourning (2 Samuel 3:35). These actions made it clear to the people that David had not ordered the killing of Abner (2 Samuel 3:37).

## 2 Samuel 3:32

By burying Abner in Hebron, which was David's capital at the time, David showed publicly that Abner now stood with him rather than with Saul. This public act likely encouraged others from the northern tribes to follow Abner's choice.

## 2 Samuel 3:33

die the death of a fool: Joab deceived Abner by pretending to be his friend. He was actually an enemy (see 2 Samuel 3:27).

## 2 Samuel 3:34

before the wicked: Normal warfare could not defeat Abner, who was an experienced warrior. He could be defeated only through betrayal.

## 2 Samuel 3:35

urged David to eat something: See also 2 Samuel 12:17.

## 2 Samuel 3:37

See study note on 2 Samuel 3:31.

## 2 Samuel 3:39

too fierce for me: Just as Ish-bosheth could not control Abner, David could not control Joab. However, David had faith that the Lord would repay Joab for murdering Abner.

## 2 Samuel 4:1

all Israel was dismayed: Abner's true power was evident in Ish-bosheth's reaction to his death (compare Joshua 2:9–11; 5:1). Ish-bosheth's lack of courage caused the same weakness among those who followed him.

## 2 Samuel 4:2–3

Beeroth was located in Benjamin near Gibeon. The people of Beeroth likely fled to Gittaim because Saul

persecuted non-Israelite residents in that region (see 2 Samuel 21:1–9). The location of Gittaim is unknown.

## 2 Samuel 4:4

- This parenthetical note shows that Saul's royal line could not continue after the death of Ish-bosheth (2 Samuel 4:5–7). The only remaining heir was a young child who was disabled (see also 2 Samuel 9:1–13).
- Mephibosheth may be a nickname that means "from the mouth of shame." This name may reflect how people viewed his physical condition. Under the law of Moses, a disabled animal could not be offered to God. A priest with a physical defect could not stand before God to present the people's offerings (Leviticus 21:19). In the same way, Mephibosheth's disability likely made him unacceptable, in the eyes of many, as a candidate for the throne.

His earlier name, Merib-baal (see 1 Chronicles 9:40), included the word baal. His later name removed any association with Baal (see study note on 2 Samuel 2:8).

## 2 Samuel 4:6

Recab and Baanah believed they would gain David's favor by committing this betrayal.

## 2 Samuel 4:8

- your enemy: As far as we know, David never referred to Saul as an enemy.
- the LORD has granted vengeance: People who do wrong things often assume that God supports their plans and use this belief to justify their desire for power. However, David refused to reward acts of betrayal.

## 2 Samuel 4:9–11

when someone told me: Compare 2 Samuel 1:1–16.

## 2 Samuel 4:12

They cut off their hands and feet: David displayed the bodies of Ish-bosheth's killers to shame them by denying them a proper burial (compare 1 Samuel 31:8–13). This public act also showed that David was not responsible for Ish-bosheth's death.

## 2 Samuel 5:1

your own flesh and blood: Years of civil war had set one Israelite against another and led to much bloodshed (see 2 Samuel 3:1).

## 2 Samuel 5:1–25

After the murder of Abner and Ish-bosheth, the elders of the northern tribes accepted David as their king. So, David gained:

- an extended empire (2 Samuel 5:1–5),
- a new capital city (2 Samuel 5:6–10),
- a new palace (2 Samuel 5:11),
- a new family (2 Samuel 5:13–16), and
- renewed confidence (2 Samuel 5:17–25).

## 2 Samuel 5:2

- you were the one: In the ancient world, a covenant relationship was sometimes formed between a ruler and the people who served him. Scholars often call this a suzerain–vassal treaty (an agreement between a powerful ruler and weaker subjects). This kind of relationship often began because the ruler had helped the people in the past, especially by rescuing them from enemies. Examples include:
- Gideon (see Judges 8:22),
- Jephthah (Judges 11:8–11), and
- Saul (1 Samuel 11:1–15).

This political practice helps explain the covenant idea in Scripture. God was Israel's covenant Lord because he had rescued them from slavery in Egypt (compare Exodus 19:4; 20:1–2).

- to you the LORD said: Israel already knew that God had chosen David as king (compare 2 Samuel 3:9).
- You will shepherd My people Israel: This phrase is quoted in Matthew 2:6 when King Herod asks the leading priests about the prophecies concerning the Messiah (God's chosen one).

## 2 Samuel 5:3

- King David made a covenant (a binding agreement) that required the people's loyalty. At the same time, it allowed each tribe to keep its identity and each person to keep dignity. The covenant served as a basic law for the nation. It included rules that obligated both the king and the people.
- they anointed him king: Although Samuel had already anointed David earlier (1 Samuel 16:13), this public ceremony showed that the people now accepted David as their king.

## 2 Samuel 5:4–5

Hebron: See study note on 2 Samuel 2:1.

## 2 Samuel 5:6

- The Jebusites lived in Jerusalem before King David captured the city (see Exodus 34:11; Deuteronomy

7:1–6; 20:17; Joshua 15:63; Judges 1:21). Nothing is known about the Jebusites outside the Bible.

Archaeological texts from Mari, in Syria, mention a similar name, Yabasi. This name appears both as a clan name and as the name of a place.

- Even the blind and lame: The Jebusites believed their city could not be captured. They thought Jerusalem was secure and impossible to defeat.

Another possible translation is, You will not enter here unless you remove the blind and the lame. This statement suggests that David's capture of Jerusalem seemed as impossible as curing blindness and lameness.

## 2 Samuel 5:6–10

David acquired a new capital city, Jerusalem, for the newly extended kingdom.

## 2 Samuel 5:7

The fortress of Zion: At this time, Jerusalem was probably a small settlement, covering about nine to twelve square acres.

The pride of the Jebusites, together with the fact that no one had captured the city before, suggests that Jerusalem had strong defenses and was well protected.

## 2 Samuel 5:8

- Scholars debate how David captured Jerusalem. One view is that David's men entered the city through a water tunnel. This tunnel may have carried water into the city and also allowed soldiers to move inside. However, not all interpreters agree with this explanation.

Another view is that David and his men captured Jerusalem through a more typical military attack. They may have built siege works (structures used to attack a city) and climbed over the city walls. The Hebrew word often translated water tunnel appears only here and in Psalm 42:7, where it is translated "waterfalls." Because of this, some scholars think the word may be figurative. In that case, it would describe the violence and intensity of the attack, not a literal tunnel.

- The blind and the lame will never enter the palace: The word palace could mean either the temple, which was not yet built, or David's palace. This saying may help explain why Mephibosheth, a descendant of Saul who was disabled, did not become king (see study note on 2 Samuel 4:4).
- David also promised that those who led the siege of Jerusalem would become commanders in his army (see 1 Chronicles 11:6).

## 2 Samuel 5:9

- took up residence in the fortress: After capturing the city, David made the fortress in Jerusalem his home. Jerusalem was a practical place for David to rule the expanded kingdom.

The city was centrally located and neutral, lying on the border between Judah and the northern territories. Its strong natural defenses and water tunnel were especially important during a siege (an attack meant to surround and cut off a city).

- the supporting terraces: See study note on 1 Kings 9:15.

## 2 Samuel 5:10

the LORD ... was with him: Although David was a skilled and charismatic leader, his growing success was ultimately due to God's blessing.

## 2 Samuel 5:11

Hiram king of Tyre: Although the meeting of these two neighboring kings is reported just after Jerusalem's conquest, it probably happened much later. Hiram remained king in Tyre until at least Solomon's twenty-fourth year. One ancient source says he was king for thirty-four years.

Another tradition suggests Hiram became king of Tyre just eight years before Solomon became king of Israel. This same king later did a similar favor for Solomon (1 Kings 5:1–18).

The report of Hiram's support is likely included here because it connects with the theme of David being confirmed and firmly established as Israel's king (2 Samuel 5:12).

## 2 Samuel 5:12

David realized that his reign as king over Israel was for the sake of God's people Israel, not just for his personal benefit or enrichment.

## 2 Samuel 5:13–16

The growth of David's family showed his increasing success and authority as king of Israel. Solomon was the most important of David's sons who were born in Jerusalem (see 2 Samuel 12:24–25).

## 2 Samuel 5:17–25

- For the first time as king, David fought the Philistines in battle.
- Up to this point in 2 Samuel, David's life follows a clear and repeated pattern:
- He was crowned king in Hebron (2 Samuel 2:4).
- He won a battle (2 Samuel 2:12–17).
- He grew stronger (2 Samuel 3:1).
- He started a large family (2 Samuel 3:2–5).

A similar pattern appears again later:

- David was crowned king in Jerusalem (2 Samuel 5:3).
- He grew stronger again (2 Samuel 5:10).
- He expanded his family (2 Samuel 5:13–14).
- He won another battle (2 Samuel 5:17–25).

This repeated pattern emphasizes both of David's coronations. Each one is marked by signs of God's blessing and success.

## 2 Samuel 5:18

The valley of Rephaim is located between Bethlehem and Jerusalem (compare 2 Samuel 23:13–14).

## 2 Samuel 5:20

Baal-perazim: David used the word Baal here to honor the Lord for the victory he gave Israel. At that time, baal could mean "lord" or "master," and it could be used as a title for the Lord.

The name Baal-perazim means "the lord of breakthroughs" or "the lord who breaks through." It likely refers to God breaking through enemy lines, like water breaking through a barrier. This title later became unacceptable because the worship of the Canaanite god Baal became a serious problem in Israel.

Every time David fought the Philistines in 2 Samuel (2 Samuel 5:17–25; 8:1; 21:15–22; 23:13–17), he won without losing a single soldier. This was very different from Saul, who could not defeat the Philistines.

## 2 Samuel 5:21

David ... carried them away: David took the Philistines' idols as revenge for their earlier capture of the ark during Eli's time (1 Samuel 4:1b–11). Instead of keeping the idols as trophies, David burned them (1 Chronicles 14:12).

## 2 Samuel 5:23

David asked the Lord again (2 Samuel 5:19), but this time God gave a much more detailed answer. Instead of a direct attack like in 2 Samuel 5:20, God told David to go around behind the enemy.

## 2 Samuel 5:25

Gibeon: David drove the Philistines out of Israel's central hills, from Gibeon in the east (in Benjamin, north of Jerusalem) to Gezer in the west.

## 2 Samuel 6:1–23

Except for a brief reference in 1 Samuel 14:18 (see note), the ark of the covenant does not appear again after 1 Samuel 7:1–2. In that passage, the Philistines returned the captured ark to Beth-shemesh, and it was later taken to Kiriath-jearim. There, the ark was placed in the home of Abinadab.

The ark's long absence during the reign of Saul is significant. It shows that Saul did not seek the Lord and was spiritually insensitive (see 1 Chronicles 10:13–14; 13:3). During Saul's forty-year reign, the ark played little or no role in Israel's worship or leadership.

In contrast, David brought the ark to Jerusalem. By doing this, David publicly acknowledged the Lord as Israel's true king in the new capital (see 2 Samuel 6:2). The ark's arrival showed that Israel's political center was now also a place of worship.

## 2 Samuel 6:2

is enthroned between the cherubim: See also 1 Samuel 4:4; 2 Kings 19:15; Psalms 80:1; 99:1.

## 2 Samuel 6:3–4

- According to God's instructions, the ark was to be carried by Levites from the clan of Kohath. They were to lift it using two poles placed through four rings at the corners of the ark (Exodus 25:14; 37:5; Numbers 4:6). In this event, the people did not follow God's instructions.
- Uzzah and Ahio: In 1 Samuel 7:1, Eleazar, another son of Abinadab, was responsible for taking care of the ark.

## 2 Samuel 6:5

The musical instruments were played by Levites (1 Chronicles 16:4–6).

## 2 Samuel 6:6–7

took hold of the ark: Uzzah likely acted with good intentions and responded quickly. However, by touching the ark, he disobeyed God's command (see Exodus 19:12–13; Numbers 4:15). As a result, he received the same punishment as the people of Beth-shemesh (1 Samuel 6:19). Later, David had the Levites carry the ark into Jerusalem, following God's instructions (see 1 Chronicles 15:2, 13–15).

## 2 Samuel 6:8

- David became angry because the LORD had burst forth: Compare Genesis 4:5, 1 Samuel 15:11, Jonah 4:1, and Luke 15:27–28.
- Perez-uzzah: The first part of this name (Perez) appears in 2 Samuel 5:20. This was where God broke through the Philistine ranks. There, it describes Baal-perazim, the place where God broke through the Philistine forces.

## 2 Samuel 6:9

David feared: Like David, Moses responded with fear when God showed his anger (Deuteronomy 9:19). Moses also trembled when God revealed his powerful and fiery presence (see Hebrews 12:21).

## 2 Samuel 6:10

Obed-edom was a Levite (1 Chronicles 15:18, 21; 16:38; 26:4, 8, 15; 2 Chronicles 25:24). He lived in either the Philistine city of Gath or an Israelite town with a similar name (for example, Gath-rimmon, a city given to the Levites, Joshua 21:25).

## 2 Samuel 6:11

God blessed Obed-edom with health, prosperity, and family. God's presence, which is a curse to the ungodly (1 Samuel 5)is a blessing to his people. Obed-edom must have taken care to preserve the ark's holiness.

## 2 Samuel 6:12

David reasoned that if God blessed Obed-edom simply for keeping the ark, then God would surely bless David for placing the ark in a special dwelling built for it in the capital city.

## 2 Samuel 6:13

David offered this sacrifice of praise to God immediately, just six steps into the journey.

## 2 Samuel 6:14

linen ephod: This word comes from the Hebrew 'epod, often written as ephod. It is related to an Akkadian word, epattu, which means "a costly garment." The ephod was often decorated with gold. People used garments like this to clothe statues of gods. Because priests and sometimes kings were seen as sacred persons (set apart for God), they wore garments of this type (see 1 Samuel 2:18, 28; 14:3; 22:18; 23:6, 9).

## 2 Samuel 6:15

In 2 Samuel 15:10, rams' horns announce the crowning of a new king. In 2 Samuel 20:1, they announce rebellion. Here, the horns celebrate placing the ark in its own tent (see study note on 2 Samuel 6:17). This action symbolically placed Yahweh's throne in Jerusalem.

## 2 Samuel 6:16

Michal is identified as the daughter of Saul three times in this chapter (2 Samuel 6:16, 20, 23). By repeatedly naming her father, the text highlights the tension in her identity. Was Michal more David's wife, or was she still Saul's daughter?

This tension also raises questions about David's motives. When David brought Michal back to him earlier (2 Samuel 3:13), did he do so because he loved her, or because she strengthened his political position?

Michal's contempt for David may have had several causes:

1. She may have thought David's behavior was inappropriate and too suggestive in front of young women.
2. She may have felt jealous because David received public honor while she remained at home as a neglected wife.
3. She may have resented David for many years of emotional distance, for taking other wives, and for separating her from her second husband, Palti (2 Samuel 3:16–17).
4. She may have felt deep sorrow over her father's death and anger that David's success came at the expense of Saul's family line (see study note on 2 Samuel 6:21)

## 2 Samuel 6:17

The special tent that David made for the ark was not as rich as the tent used during the wilderness wanderings. Even so, it returned Israel to an older wilderness tradition that had ended two generations earlier, when Shiloh was destroyed (Psalm 78:60–61).

David's tent was the final form of the tabernacle. Solomon, David's successor, later built a permanent temple for the Lord.

This event was a time of joy, not sorrow for sin. Because of this, the people offered burnt offerings and peace offerings, but they did not offer sin offerings or guilt offerings.

### 2 Samuel 6:18

blessed the people: Blessing the people was usually the role of priests. However, kings also gave blessings at important national events. This happened with Solomon and with Hezekiah (1 Kings 8:14, 55; 2 Chronicles 6:3; 2 Chronicles 31:8).

### 2 Samuel 6:19

David's gifts of food to every Israelite anticipated other royal gifts they would receive while he was king.

### 2 Samuel 6:21

David's response to Michal may suggest the deeper reason for her anger. She may have resented David's success because her father's family was losing power and honor.

### 2 Samuel 6:22

David could not hold back his excitement while celebrating before the Lord. In fact, he became even more enthusiastic than before.

### 2 Samuel 6:23

Michal was the only one of David's many wives who did not have a child by him. After she showed contempt for David's joyful worship, the text states that she had no children for the rest of her life. Some scholars think this suggests that God prevented her from having children as judgment for her contempt toward David's joyful worship (compare Genesis 20:17–18). Another possibility is that David and Michal's marriage became so damaged that they no longer lived together as husband and wife.

Because Michal remained childless, another line of Saul's family came to an end. This moment marks Michal's final appearance in the biblical account.

### 2 Samuel 7:1

from all ... enemies: See Deuteronomy 12:9–10; 1 Kings 5:4; 8:56. David's peace was brief because he soon went back to war (see 2 Samuel 8:1–18).

### 2 Samuel 7:1–2

If God had only a tent while David had a palace, people might think David was the true king instead of God. So, David planned to build a temple for God.

### 2 Samuel 7:1–29

David was not happy just making a tent for the ark (2 Samuel 6:17). He wanted to build a house for God.

### 2 Samuel 7:2

- Nathan is recorded in David's life on three occasions:

1. here with a promise for David;
2. in 2 Samuel 12:1–15 with a parable of judgment against David;
3. in 1 Kings 1:11–27 with a plan for making Solomon David's successor.

- A cedar palace would have been made of stone with cedar paneling inside.

### 2 Samuel 7:3

Go and do all that is in your heart: Nathan's counsel to David was Nathan's own idea. As it turned out, God disqualified David from building the temple (see 1 Chronicles 22:8). Even true prophets can make mistakes when they speak from their own ideas instead of God's guidance.

### 2 Samuel 7:5

Are you the one?: God wanted someone to build a house for him, but David was not the right person.

### 2 Samuel 7:6

have not dwelt in a house: Before the temple was built in one location, God lived in the tabernacle. The tabernacle was a portable, tent-like structure. The text here uses language of human experience to describe a truth about God (see study notes on Exodus 29:18; Deuteronomy 8:2). Although God is present everywhere, he chose the tabernacle and later the temple as his "dwelling place" in ancient Israel (see study note on 2 Chronicles 2:5–6; compare Acts 17:24).

### 2 Samuel 7:7

have I ever asked: Although it was less impressive than the temple, the tabernacle honored God because God had chosen it for use during that period of Israel's history.

### 2 Samuel 7:8

following the flock: In the ancient Near East, people often described kings as shepherds because they were expected to guide and protect their people (see 1 Kings 22:17; Isaiah 44:28; Ezekiel 34:2; 37:24; Nahum 3:18; Zechariah 10:3). David had once been a shepherd himself, and he later described the Lord as his shepherd (Psalm 23:1).

## 2 Samuel 7:8–17

Instead of David building a house for God, God promised to build a house for David, meaning a lasting line of kings from David's family.

## 2 Samuel 7:9

- I have been with you: God guided and protected David throughout his life. In this way, God was actively involved in shaping everything David did.
- I will make for you a name like the greatest in the land: God promised to make a person's name great only to Abraham and to David (see Genesis 12:2).

## 2 Samuel 7:10–11

be disturbed no more: Through David and his descendants, God promised lasting peace in the land. This promise contrasted with the time of the judges, when peace came only for short periods and was often broken by attacks from other nations. God first promised "rest from all your enemies" through Joshua (Joshua 1:13, 15; 22:4). This promise was later fulfilled for limited times during the leadership of some of the judges (Judges 3:11, 30; 5:31; 8:28).

## 2 Samuel 7:11

He Himself will establish a house for you: God planned to do far more for David than David imagined doing for God. David focused on visible projects, such as building a temple. God focused instead on blessing his people through a lasting and righteous family line of kings.

## 2 Samuel 7:12–13

He will build a house for My Name: David's son Solomon would build the temple. David's personal involvement in wars and bloodshed disqualified him from building God's temple (1 Chronicles 22:8–9).

## 2 Samuel 7:14

- I will be his Father, and he will be My son: The kings who came from David's family had a special covenant relationship with God (a relationship based on God's promises). This relationship was similar to the one God had with the whole nation of Israel (compare Exodus 6:7; Leviticus 26:12).

Jesus later became the fullest and final fulfillment of this promise (see Hebrews 1:5). Paul also quoted this statement and applied it to all believers (2 Corinthians 6:18).

- When he does wrong, I will discipline him: God promised to correct and guide David's descendants, the future kings of Israel, when they sinned. In this way, God would help them return to faithful obedience. Jesus never sinned, but he still experienced suffering and learned obedience through what he endured (see Hebrews 4:15; 5:8; 12:1–11).

## 2 Samuel 7:16

forever … forever: God's promises do not cancel human responsibility or accountability (2 Samuel 7:14). When people do wrong, God responds with justice and discipline. However, no unfaithful son of David could cause God to take back his promise to preserve David's royal family. Even though the dynasty ended for many centuries, God renewed David's house and kingdom in Jesus Christ. Jesus is the sinless descendant of David, and he reigns forever.

## 2 Samuel 7:18

David's question, "Who am I?" was an expression of genuine humility (compare Exodus 4:11).

## 2 Samuel 7:18–29

David responded with prayer to God's promise that his family would rule as kings for many generations. In his prayer, he repeatedly acknowledged that God alone is the true king and Sovereign Lord.

## 2 Samuel 7:19

God's plan for David's family line of kings extended far beyond David's lifetime. This promise is fulfilled forever in the eternal reign of Jesus Christ (Revelation 11:15).

## 2 Samuel 7:20

For You know Your servant: God made his promises to David with full knowledge that David had both strengths and weaknesses.

## 2 Samuel 7:21

- David achieved great things because of God's will, not his own ambition.
- You have accomplished: David spoke about what God promised to do for his descendants over many generations as if it had already happened. This shows David's firm trust in God's faithfulness.

## 2 Samuel 7:22

there is none like You: David affirms God's uniqueness (see also 2 Samuel 22:32; Deuteronomy 4:39; 1 Samuel 2:2).

## 2 Samuel 7:23

Israel was set apart from every other nation by the uniqueness of its God and by the relationship the people had with him.

## 2 Samuel 7:24

David praised God for his goodness in redeeming and establishing the nation of Israel (2 Samuel 7:23–24), not only for blessing David and his royal family (2 Samuel 7:18–21). His prayer speaks for the whole people, not just for himself.

## 2 Samuel 7:25

confirm forever the word You have spoken: David was not asking God for a sign (as Gideon had done, see Judges 6:17). Instead, David was saying, "God, let it happen."

## 2 Samuel 7:26

God promised to make David's name great (2 Samuel 7:9), but David wanted to honor God's name. David knew that his family line would have no value unless God remained the center of the people's praise.

## 2 Samuel 8:1–18

David's military victories expanded his kingdom (2 Samuel 8:1–14). He also set up an organized group of officials who helped govern the nation (2 Samuel 8:15–18). Together, these developments fulfilled God's promise to make David's name well known and honored (2 Samuel 7:9; see also 8:13).

## 2 Samuel 8:2

- Moab was on the east side of the Dead Sea. Earlier, the people of Moab had provided David's parents with refuge during Saul's reign (1 Samuel 22:3–4). David's great-grandmother Ruth came from Moab. By David's time, however, there was no longer a close or friendly relationship between Israel and Moab.
- two lengths those to be put to death, and with one length those to be spared: This is the only time in 2 Samuel that David executed captives taken in battle (see Numbers 21:29; 24:17; Deuteronomy 2:9).

## 2 Samuel 8:3

- Hadadezer appears again in 2 Samuel 10:16 as David's enemy. He may have been the direct son and successor of Rehob. Or he may have been the ruling king from a royal family begun by a king named Rehob. This kingdom was located near the northern city of Dan (see Judges 18:28; compare Numbers 13:21).
- Zobah was north and east of David's kingdom.
- who had marched out: The Hebrew text uses a pronoun that simply means "he." This could refer to Hadadezer, as the Berean Standard Bible translates it. However, some interpreters suggest it could refer to David, meaning that David marched out to strengthen his control over the region.
- The Euphrates River: The Hebrew text says only "the river." First Chronicles 18:3 clearly identifies this river as the Euphrates River. Compare 2 Samuel 10:16.

## 2 Samuel 8:4

David would have disabled horses to stop the enemy from using them again. He also did this because kings in Israel were not allowed to gather large numbers of horses (Deuteronomy 17:16).

## 2 Samuel 8:5

Hadadezer's neighbors, the Arameans from Damascus, were unable to help him resist David. They later had more success against Solomon (1 Kings 11:23–25). But they were less successful when they attacked Samaria during the reign of King Ahab of Israel (1 Kings 20).

## 2 Samuel 8:6

- Garrisons were groups of soldiers placed in a territory to keep control and prevent rebellion. David placed army garrisons in Aram, but not in Moab (2 Samuel 8:2). This difference suggests that Aram was a stronger and more dangerous enemy. David needed a military presence there in order to keep control.
- the LORD made David victorious: See 2 Samuel 8:14. God was the true source of David's success and growing power.

## 2 Samuel 8:7

- gold shields: See 2 Kings 11:10.
- brought ... to Jerusalem: David brought these valuable items to Jerusalem and dedicated them to God. He did this in keeping with God's instructions for a faithful king, which warned against storing up wealth for personal glory (Deuteronomy 17:17). Instead of keeping the gold for himself, David set it apart for God's use (see 2 Samuel 8:11).

## 2 Samuel 8:9

Hamath was northwest of Hadadezer's city, Zobah.

## 2 Samuel 8:10

- his son: King Toi sent his own son instead of another group of messengers because he believed this mission was very important. By sending the crown prince, Toi showed that he wanted to keep a strong and respectful relationship with David.
- Joram: The name Joram includes the prefix Jo-, which is a shortened form of the name Yahweh. The name means "Yahweh is exalted." In 1 Chronicles 18:10, the prince's name is Hadoram, which means "Hadad [a Canaanite god] is exalted." It is possible that Toi used the name Joram for this visit to make his son's name more acceptable to David for political reasons.

## 2 Samuel 8:11–12

Captured war booty and gifts from foreign rulers were placed in God's treasury, not in the king's treasury. David dedicated both voluntary gifts (2 Samuel 8:11a) and goods taken from defeated enemies (2 Samuel 8:11b–12) to the Lord, instead of keeping them for himself.

## 2 Samuel 8:13–14

- These two verses describe three of **David**'s military policies:

1. He inflicted heavy losses on the enemy (about 18,000 casualties).
2. He forced them into vassalage (they became subject to David's rule).
3. He placed army garrisons in the conquered land to keep control.

- Edomites: In the ancient Hebrew script, the word Edomites looks very similar to Arameans. However, Edomites is more likely here. The Valley of Salt lies near the Dead Sea, which borders Edomite territory, not Aramean territory.

## 2 Samuel 8:15–18

David organized his government with several key officials:

1. Joab led the army as the military commander.
2. Jehoshaphat kept records of important events as the court historian.
3. Zadok and Ahimelech served as priests.
4. Seraiah handled official documents and correspondence as the court secretary.
5. Benaiah was the security officer in charge of the royal guard. He later became a commander under Solomon (see also 1 Kings 2:25–46).

## 2 Samuel 8:18

- The king's bodyguard included the Cherethites and Pelethites, who were likely foreigners. The Cherethites might have come from Crete (see also 1 Samuel 30:14; Ezekiel 25:16). These groups could have been Philistine mercenaries.
- David's sons were priestly leaders: David was from Judah and not a Levite (only people from the tribe of Levi could usually serve as priests). David may have created a new group of religious servants connected to his family line of kings to serve the king's court. This was different from the normal priests who served at the temple (see also study note on 2 Samuel 20:26).

## 2 Samuel 9:1

- show kindness: The Hebrew word khesed refers to covenant loyalty and faithfulness (steadfast commitment within a relationship). It often describes God's faithful commitment to his people. It can also describe deep devotion and loyalty between two people.

Here, David uses khesed in a way that echoes the covenant of friendship he made with Jonathan (1 Samuel 20:12–17).

- for the sake of Jonathan: David showed kindness because of his promise to Jonathan. Mephibosheth was Saul's only remaining descendant and Jonathan's only son.

## 2 Samuel 9:1–13

David showed mercy to Mephibosheth, the disabled son of Jonathan. This account appears between reports of David's military victories (2 Samuel 8:1–18, 10). Its placement shows that David not only achieved success in war but also cared for individuals and acted with compassion.

## 2 Samuel 9:3

Mephibosheth was disabled in both feet because of an accident when he was a child (see 2 Samuel 4:4).

## 2 Samuel 9:4

- Lo-debar was a small town in northern Transjordan (the area east of the Jordan River). It was close to Mahanaim, the capital city of Mephibosheth's uncle, Ish-bosheth, who had died by this time.

Lo-debar was also near Jabesh-gilead, where Saul first gained public support as a leader (1 Samuel 11:1–13).

- Makir son of Ammiel, who hosted Mephibosheth in Lo-debar, later supported David during Absalom's revolt (2 Samuel 17:27).

## 2 Samuel 9:5

As Saul had once sent for David (1 Samuel 16:19), now David sent for Mephibosheth. However, Saul sent for someone to minister to him, whereas David sent for someone to whom he could minister.

## 2 Samuel 9:6

Because of Mephibosheth's physical limitations, bowing low to the ground must have been very difficult.

## 2 Samuel 9:7

David took all the property that had belonged to Saul.

## 2 Samuel 9:8

a dead dog like me: Mephibosheth understood that anyone who might claim the throne could be killed as a potential threat to the king.

## 2 Samuel 9:11

Both Ziba and Mephibosheth (2 Samuel 9:6) used the phrase "I am your servant" when they met King David. By calling himself David's servant, Ziba showed he was no longer loyal to Saul's family. Later events raised questions about the sincerity of both Mephibosheth and Ziba (2 Samuel 16:1–4; 19:17–30).

## 2 Samuel 9:13

lame in both feet: See 2 Samuel 4:4.

## 2 Samuel 10:1

Some time later: King Hadadezer appears in 2 Samuel 10:1–19 as a strong opponent of David (2 Samuel 10:16). This seems surprising, because David had already defeated Hadadezer earlier and taken plunder from his city (2 Samuel 8:3; 7, 12). There are two possible explanations. Either Hadadezer was still alive, rebuilt his forces, and rebelled again in 2 Samuel 10:1–19. Or, 10:1–19 explains in more detail the events summarized in 8:1–18 and prepares the reader for what happens next in 11:1–27.

## 2 Samuel 10:1–5

The king of Ammon insulted David's ambassadors, which led to two battles between Israel and Ammon (2 Samuel 10:6–12:31).

## 2 Samuel 10:1–19

After the break in 2 Samuel 9, the story goes back to David's military successes. The Ammonites were likely the dominant political power in Transjordan (the area east of the Jordan) during Saul's reign and the early years of David's reign.

## 2 Samuel 10:2

In both 2 Samuel 9 and 10, David wanted to show loyalty (chesed, a Hebrew word meaning faithful love and committed kindness). This word also appears in 2 Samuel 9:1, 3.

## 2 Samuel 10:4

- This act was meant to cause extreme shame and public ridicule. In that culture, a man's beard was a sign of honor and dignity. Cutting off only half made the humiliation visible and impossible to hide.
- cut off their garments: This action exposed the men's bodies and brought further shame. Public exposure of the body was linked with military defeat and exile in the ancient world (Isaiah 20). The prophet Isaiah describes similar acts of humiliation connected with conquest and captivity.

## 2 Samuel 10:5

The city of Jericho had not been officially rebuilt (see 1 Kings 16:34). However, the site lay next to the largest and most reliable spring in the land, so people continued to live nearby.

Anyone traveling from Ammon to Jerusalem would pass by this area. Because of this, Jericho provided a quiet and private place where the men could stay hidden while they recovered from their humiliation.

## 2 Samuel 10:6

- Aramean foot soldiers: See 2 Samuel 8:5–6.
- Beth-rehob and Zobah: See 2 Samuel 8:3, 12.
- Tob may refer to a smaller kingdom and region ruled by a vassal king (a local ruler under the control of a stronger king). In this case, Tob was likely under the authority of Hadadezer.

## 2 Samuel 10:8

The Israelites had a double battle: against the Ammonites in front of their fortifications at the entrance of the city gate and against the Aramean army in the open fields.

## 2 Samuel 10:12

Be strong: Before battles, a priest or leader often gave speeches to encourage the people (compare Numbers 31:6; Deuteronomy 20:2; Judges 4:14; 1 Samuel 4:4; 14:3; 23:9).

## 2 Samuel 10:16

- Hadadezer: See study note on 2 Samuel 10:1.
- The location of Helam is unknown.
- This passage suggests that David had expanded his kingdom as far north as the Euphrates River (see also study note on 2 Samuel 8:3).

## 2 Samuel 11:1

- In the spring of the year, the land began to dry out after the heavy winter rains. Kings avoided war during the rainy season.
- David stayed behind either because he was irresponsible in carrying out his royal duties or because he trusted Joab to efficiently handle the Ammonite problem (compare 2 Samuel 10:7). This is the first mention of a leader of Israel staying off the battlefield in a time of war.

## 2 Samuel 11:1–27

David's affair with Bathsheba and the murder of her husband Uriah show that David was capable of serious moral failure. These actions deeply damaged David's life and leadership.

These failures took place during a period when David was enjoying major military success against the Ammonites (2 Samuel 10:1–11:1; 12:26–31).

## 2 Samuel 11:2

- strolled around on the roof: The roofs of houses were flat and often used for different activities, like drying and storing food (Joshua 2:6), walking and socializing, and sleeping in warm weather.
- Bathsheba was bathing in clear view from the roof of the king's palace. She might have thought everyone was inside, escaping the heat or taking a midday rest.

## 2 Samuel 11:3

- Bathsheba means "daughter of seven" or "daughter of oath." Her father, Eliam, was the son of Ahithophel (see 2 Samuel 23:34), an adviser first to David and then to Absalom (2 Samuel 15:12; 16:23). Ahithophel later switched his support from David to Absalom (2 Samuel 17:1–4, 14), which upset David. He advised Absalom to sleep with David's concubines on a rooftop, where everyone could see (2 Samuel 16:20–22).
- Uriah is a Hebrew name meaning "Yahweh is my light." He might have been a foreign soldier, a convert to the Israelite religion, or an Israelite with Hittite ancestry. Uriah could also have been part of the non-Israelite nobility in Jerusalem before David conquered the city. He was one of David's 30 mightiest warriors (2 Samuel 23:39).

## 2 Samuel 11:4

- It is not clear whether Bathsheba came to David's palace by her own choice. David was the king, and Bathsheba was a subject under his authority. This unequal power relationship means that she may not have been free to refuse his summons.

The text does not record any protest from Bathsheba, unlike other passages where protest is clearly stated (compare 2 Samuel 13:12–13). Afterward, she married David, bore him another son, and later urged David to name their son as heir (1 Kings 1:11–21). These details may suggest willing cooperation.
However, other details point in a different direction. Bathsheba mourned for her husband Uriah (2 Samuel 11:26–27), and the text places blame only on David for what happened (2 Samuel 11:27). Given David's authority and Bathsheba's vulnerable position, it is also possible that she was taken against her will.

- The phrase about her menstrual period (see Leviticus 15:19–24) shows that Bathsheba could not have been pregnant by Uriah. It makes clear that the child she conceived must have been David's.

## 2 Samuel 11:8

- wash your feet: David assumed that Uriah would have sex with Bathsheba while on this weekend pass. Then everyone except Bathsheba would assume that the child was Uriah's, conceived on this night.
- a gift: David may not have cared whether Uriah and Bathsheba were actually intimate. If Uriah had gone back to his house, people would have assumed that the pregnancy began during that time. This would have prevented questions about when and how Bathsheba became pregnant.

## 2 Samuel 11:11

- in tents (Hebrew, sukkoth, the name behind Sukkot, "the Feast of Tabernacles," Deuteronomy 16:13–17): These were temporary shelters made of branches and leaves. Soldiers in battle, herders watching their

animals, or workers during the grape harvest used these shelters.
- eat and drink and sleep with my wife?: Uriah was willing to eat and drink with David (2 Samuel 11:13). What he refused was to sleep with his wife, Bathsheba. In ancient Israel, soldiers on duty treated the camp as a holy place because they believed God was present there to fight for them. For that reason, they avoided anything considered impure, including sexual relations (Leviticus 15:18; see also 1 Samuel 21:5–6).

## 2 Samuel 11:16–17

Uriah was not the only one who died. David sacrificed several other Israelite soldiers while attempting to hide his sin.

## 2 Samuel 11:21

Was it not a woman who dropped an upper millstone on him: Compare Judges 9:54.

## 2 Samuel 11:25

the sword devours one as well as another: David spoke as if death in war were random and unavoidable. His words show a cold and careless attitude toward the unnecessary deaths he had caused.

## 2 Samuel 12:1

- The Lord sent Nathan to David at least nine months after David committed adultery.
- This account is one of the few places in the Old Testament that uses a parable (a short story that teaches a moral truth; see also Judges 9:8–15). Parables can communicate truth in a powerful and indirect way.
- David was rich in many ways. He possessed royal wealth, had many wives, and held God's promises for his future. By contrast, Uriah was poor. He had one wife, one home, and no continuing family line.

## 2 Samuel 12:1–31

Chapter 12 expands on the final part of 2 Samuel 11:27.

## 2 Samuel 12:3

like a daughter: Nathan compares the lamb to a daughter. The Hebrew word for "daughter" is bath. This creates a word connection with Bathsheba's name, which begins with bath (see study note on 2 Samuel 11:3). This comparison strengthens the emotional force of the story and helps David recognize the injustice of his actions.

## 2 Samuel 12:4

he took the poor man's lamb: Samuel had previously warned that a king would take what was not his (1 Samuel 8:11–17).

## 2 Samuel 12:5–6

The rich man of the parable did not deserve to die according to the law; instead, he must repay four lambs (compare Exodus 22:1). Interestingly, David later lost four of his sons:

- Bathsheba's first child (2 Samuel 12:18)
- Amnon (2 Samuel 13:29)
- Absalom (2 Samuel 18:14–15)
- Adonijah (1 Kings 2:25)

## 2 Samuel 12:7–8

- You are that man!: David did deserve to die for his crime (Leviticus 20:10).
- I anointed ... I gave ... I would have given you: David's sin broke God's laws against murder, adultery, and coveting (Exodus 20:1–17). It also showed a bold disrespect for everything the Lord had kindly given him.

## 2 Samuel 12:8

His wives were likely concubines from Saul's harem (see 2 Samuel 3:7). The phrase might refer to Saul's wife Ahinoam, but David probably married another woman with the same name (see 1 Samuel 14:50; 25:43).

## 2 Samuel 12:10

- Now (literally forever): This phrase points to ongoing consequences. It stands in contrast to God's gracious promises of a lasting kingdom that God gave to David earlier (2 Samuel 7:13–29).
- This is a reminder of what David did with the sword (2 Samuel 12:9) and how the sword would affect his family. This recalls David's careless reaction to Joab's report about the deaths of Uriah and other innocent Israelites (2 Samuel 11:25).

## 2 Samuel 12:11

I will raise up adversity against you from your own house: Absalom's revolt against David fulfilled this promise (2 Samuel 14–19).

## 2 Samuel 12:14

Nevertheless ... the son born to you will surely die: At times, God allows the consequences of a father's sin to affect later generations (Exodus 20:5; 34:7; Numbers 14:18; Deuteronomy 5:9; Jeremiah 32:18). Although

David repented and God forgave him (2 Samuel 12:13), this forgiveness did not remove all consequences. Instead, the punishment was delayed and carried forward into a later generation (see 1 Kings 21:27–29).

## 2 Samuel 12:20

The series of actions described here show David resuming normal life activities. That he did so this soon after his son's death amazed his advisers s (2 Samuel 12:21).

## 2 Samuel 12:21–23

David mourned and fasted before his son died, hoping that God would remove the punishment.

## 2 Samuel 12:23

Can I bring him back again? I will go to him: The finality of his son's death forced David to face his own mortality. At the same time, his words express confidence that life continues after death and that he would one day join his son.

## 2 Samuel 12:24

- Even after Uriah's death, Bathsheba was still referred to as Uriah's wife (2 Samuel 12:9; see also Matthew 1:6). Only here is she called David's wife.
- Solomon: In Hebrew, Solomon's name is pronounced Shelomoh. It likely means "his peace," from the Hebrew word shalom (peace).

The name may also mean "his replacement." This meaning comes from the Hebrew root shelem, which can mean "replacement" or "compensation." Similar names include Shelemiah (Jeremiah 36:14), which means "Yahweh has provided compensation," and Shelumiel (Numbers 1:6), which means "God is my compensation." Both meanings fit the context of Solomon's birth after the loss of David and Bathsheba's first child.

## 2 Samuel 12:25

Jedidiah means "loved by Yahweh." This second name, which God gave to Solomon, appears only here in the Bible. It expresses God's special love for him and points to God's intention to secure Solomon's future.

## 2 Samuel 12:26–31

David's fight with the Ammonites, which began in 2 Samuel 10, ended in success.

## 2 Samuel 12:30

- he took the crown: By taking the crown, David effectively showed that he now ruled over the Ammonites, as if he had become their king.
- a great amount of plunder: The law warned Israel not to take certain kinds of war booty during conquest because of its danger (Deuteronomy 7:25–26). The wealth David took was dangerous. Riches could turn his heart away from God if he trusted them instead of the Lord.

## 2 Samuel 12:31

He also enslaved the people of Rabbah, forcing them to work. Enslaving defeated peoples followed the rules in Deuteronomy 20:11. Solomon later did the same with the Canaanites (1 Kings 9:20–22; see also Judges 1:30, 33). Another interpretation suggests the defeated Ammonites were tortured (compare textual note on 1 Chronicles 20:3).

## 2 Samuel 13:1

the beautiful sister: Tamar was the full sister of Absalom, but only the half sister of Amnon (see 2 Samuel 3:2–3). As Tamar's closest male relative, Absalom later took action to avenge her (2 Samuel 13:23–29; compare Genesis 34; Numbers 35:19).

## 2 Samuel 13:2

- sick with frustration: The story shows that Amnon's "love" for Tamar (2 Samuel 13:4) was not healthy love. It was an unhealthy sexual obsession that made him emotionally distressed.
- She was a virgin: Amnon's fixation grew stronger because Tamar had not had sexual relations.
- it seemed implausible for him to do anything to her: The law forbade marriage between a brother and a sister (Leviticus 18:9, 11; 20:17; Deuteronomy 27:22). However, Amnon did not seek marriage with Tamar. He wanted only to have sex with her.

## 2 Samuel 13:3

- shrewd (literally wise): Jonadab's "wisdom" was similar to the serpent's cleverness (Genesis 3:1).
- In the context of a royal court, the Hebrew term for friend is closer to "counselor" or "adviser."

## 2 Samuel 13:4

morning after morning: Amnon's obsession grew stronger and never stopped.

## 2 Samuel 13:12

- disgraceful thing: The Hebrew word nebalah means "outrage" or "deplorable act." It often refers to sexual crimes like rape and adultery (Genesis 34:7; Deuteronomy 22:21; Judges 20:6, 10; Jeremiah 29:23). The person responsible must pay with his life.
- in Israel: The added phrase either shows outrage that such a crime took place among Israelites, or it describes the act as a serious violation of Israel's standards for sexual behavior.

## 2 Samuel 13:13

he will not withhold me from you: Tamar said this to gain time. Amnon knew that the law prohibited marriage between half-siblings (see study note on 2 Samuel 13:2), and he refused to stop.

## 2 Samuel 13:14

being stronger: Tamar resisted as much as she could.

## 2 Samuel 13:15

The fact that Amnon's feelings for Tamar quickly changed into hate shows that what he called "love" (2 Samuel 13:4) was actually selfish sexual desire, not genuine care for her.

## 2 Samuel 13:16

worse than this great wrong you have already done: In that culture, a virgin who had been raped was considered unable to marry (2 Samuel 13:20; see Deuteronomy 22:28–29).

## 2 Samuel 13:18

a robe of many colors: This phrase also describes Joseph's robe in Genesis 37:3.

## 2 Samuel 13:19

- Tamar tore her robe to show the loss of her virginity and honor and to mourn her future's end (2 Samuel 13:16).
- Ashes symbolized death; sitting in ashes or placing ashes on one's head were signs of mourning (Esther 4:1–3; Job 42:6; Daniel 9:3; Jonah 3:6).

## 2 Samuel 13:20

- Be quiet for now ... Do not take this thing to heart: Absalom's words sound comforting, but they do not match Tamar's deep shame and grief. This restrained response hid Absalom's intense anger (2 Samuel 13:22) from Tamar, who was already overwhelmed.
- as a desolate woman: See study note on 2 Samuel 13:16.

## 2 Samuel 13:21

King David ... was furious: David was deeply angry about what happened, but he does not seem to have punished Amnon.

Some ancient texts, including the Dead Sea Scrolls and the Greek version, add an explanation. They say David did not punish Amnon because he loved him. Another possibility is that David, who had committed sexual sin himself (see 2 Samuel 11:1–12:24), felt unable to judge his son for a similar offense. A third possibility is that David saw this event as a form of God's "eye for an eye" judgment for his own wrongdoing.

## 2 Samuel 13:23

- Baal-hazor is different from the well-known fortified city of Hazor, which is north of the Sea of Galilee. A fortified city is a city protected by strong walls and defenses. Baal-hazor is believed to be at Jebel el-Asur, about 24 kilometers (15 miles) north of Jerusalem.
- he invited all the sons of the king: Sheep shearing was a time to share abundance and blessings with others (see 1 Samuel 25:2–8).

## 2 Samuel 13:31

David tore his robe, just like Tamar did after being harmed (2 Samuel 13:19). This act showed deep distress or regret (see also Genesis 37:34).

## 2 Samuel 13:34–39

Absalom was now a fugitive. He sought refuge among his mother's family.

## 2 Samuel 13:37

- fled and went to Talmai: See 2 Samuel 3:3.
- Geshur was in Aram, northeast of Israel's territory (see 2 Samuel 15:8; Joshua 13:13).

## 2 Samuel 13:39

- And King David: The Dead Sea Scrolls and Greek version say And the spirit of the king.
- longed to go to Absalom: David's intense grief over Amnon's death had eased. Any desire he may have had to put Absalom to death had faded, and he now wanted to restore their relationship.

### 2 Samuel 14:2

The woman with a reputation for great wisdom was summoned to carry out a delicate mission in the royal court (compare 2 Samuel 20:16).

### 2 Samuel 14:9

My lord the king, may any blame be on me: If David allowed a murder to go unpunished, he would fail to uphold justice and would likely be criticized by the people.

### 2 Samuel 14:11

As surely as the LORD lives: When the woman urged David to promise more protection, he responded with this solemn oath (see 2 Samuel 4:9; 12:5; 15:21; 1 Samuel 20:3; 28:10; 29:6).

### 2 Samuel 14:13

against the people of God: The woman argued that David was harming the entire kingdom by keeping Absalom in exile. She suggested that conflict in the royal family would spread to the wider society, or that David's focus on Absalom would distract him from ruling well (2 Samuel 14:16).

### 2 Samuel 14:14

God ... devises ways: The woman encouraged David to make peace with Absalom, just as God does with his people. God did not stay distant from David when he sinned. He forgave the king when he repented.

### 2 Samuel 14:16

- The woman again spoke about her own case. She argued that the king's concern for Absalom kept him from addressing justice among his people (see 2 Samuel 13:39 and study note on 2 Samuel 13:39).
- cut off both: If her only remaining son were killed, her family would lose its ancestral land (compare Numbers 27:1–11).

### 2 Samuel 14:17

just like the angel of God: This expression shows great respect. It is not used for anyone else in the Bible and appears four times in reference to David (see also 2 Samuel 14:20; 19:27; 1 Samuel 29:9). The woman was expressing confidence that David would act with wisdom and justice given by God.

### 2 Samuel 14:20

has wisdom like the wisdom of the angel of God: This wise woman (2 Samuel 14:2) knew it was better to praise a king than to insult him.

### 2 Samuel 14:21

bring back ... Absalom: It seems that David was not yet interested in full reconciliation with his son (2 Samuel 14:24).

### 2 Samuel 14:23

Geshur: See 2 Samuel 13:37–38.

### 2 Samuel 14:26

he shaved it every year: Absalom's hair, which made him attractive, became a deadly trap for him (see 2 Samuel 18:9–15).

### 2 Samuel 14:27

- Absalom's three sons likely died before him (see 2 Samuel 18:18).
- Absalom named his daughter Tamar after his sister, and she was also very beautiful (2 Samuel 13:1).

### 2 Samuel 14:29

Joab persuaded David to welcome Absalom back (2 Samuel 14:21–22). However, he then stopped helping Absalom, possibly to avoid supporting someone who might try to take the throne (2 Samuel 15:1–12).

### 2 Samuel 14:33

- Absalom bowed deeply, showing respect to the king (see also 2 Samuel 4:4, 22).
- the king kissed Absalom: The absence of talking, hugging (compare Luke 15:20), or crying (compare Genesis 33:4; 45:2, 14) suggests this was a formal meeting, not an affectionate reunion.

### 2 Samuel 15:1

a chariot with horses and fifty men: These items were clear signs of kingship. Samuel warned that a king would take these from the people (1 Samuel 8:11). David's son, Adonijah, also gathered these when he wanted to be king (1 Kings 1:5).

### 2 Samuel 15:1–19

Absalom revolted against David eleven years after Amnon violated Tamar (compare 2 Samuel 13:23, 38; 14:28; 15:7). This was around the twenty-fifth year of David's thirty-three-year rule in Jerusalem.

## 2 Samuel 15:5

Bowing before Absalom was to honor him as king (see 2 Samuel 14:33).

## 2 Samuel 15:6

Absalom welcomed the people and acted as if he cared about them. In this way, he won their loyalty through false concern.

## 2 Samuel 15:7

- After four years: The Hebrew text says forty years, which would place Absalom's rebellion in David's final year as king, causing many timeline issues with later events (also see study note on 2 Samuel 15:1–19). The Greek and Syriac versions are more likely accurate.
- fulfill a vow: This offering was to keep a promise to God, unlike a freewill offering given out of devotion and gratitude (see Genesis 28:20–22; Judges 11:30–31; 1 Samuel 1:11). Absalom was probably lying (compare 1 Samuel 20:28–29).

## 2 Samuel 15:8

- Geshur of Aram: After killing Amnon, Absalom had sought refuge in the homeland of his mother (see study notes on 2 Samuel 13:34–39, 37).
- Hebron, David's first capital, was the ideal place for Absalom to turn his local popularity into a full revolt against David.

## 2 Samuel 15:12

- Ahithophel was Bathsheba's grandfather (see 2 Samuel 11:3; 23:34). Years later, he might have still been upset about David's actions toward his granddaughter.
- Giloh was located in the region of Hebron (Joshua 15:51, 54).

## 2 Samuel 15:15–16

David might have left ten of his concubines behind because he thought his exile would be brief. See 2 Samuel 16:21–22.

## 2 Samuel 15:18

- six hundred Gittites: This alliance began with David's connection to the Philistines during Saul's time (1 Samuel 21:10–15; 27:1–12; 29:1–11).
- the Cherethites and Pelethites: Refer to the study note on 2 Samuel 8:18.

## 2 Samuel 15:19

- Ittai was a Philistine from Gath. He was associated with Gibeah in Benjamin (2 Samuel 23:29; 1 Chronicles 11:31). The Philistines had set up a military post in Gibeah at the start of Saul's rule (1 Samuel 10:5; 13:3).
- David was stepping aside for King Absalom, who had gained the loyalty of the people of Israel.

## 2 Samuel 15:23

The Kidron Valley, east of Jerusalem, separated the City of David from the Mount of Olives.

## 2 Samuel 15:24

Zadok was one of two priests who served King David (2 Samuel 8:17). He later anointed Solomon as king (1 Kings 1:39) and became the high priest after Abiathar lost his position (1 Kings 2:26–27).

## 2 Samuel 15:25

Return the ark of God: When people fled invasions, they usually took their idols to prevent enemies from capturing them. If a god was captured, rebels might think the gods had abandoned the ruling family. However, the ark was not just an idol or charm (compare 1 Samuel 4:3–11; 5:6–6:9). It was the main object in the sanctuary and symbolized the presence of the Lord, the God of Israel (see Exodus 40:34–35). David allowed the ark to fall into Absalom's hands on purpose, trusting in God's grace and promises (2 Samuel 15:26; see 7:8–16) whether or not the ark was with him.

## 2 Samuel 15:27

Ahimaaz and Jonathan supported David during Absalom's rebellion by serving as secret messengers (see 2 Samuel 15:36; 17:17–22).

## 2 Samuel 15:31

turn the counsel of Ahithophel into foolishness: David also sent Hushai, who pretended to support Absalom while secretly serving David. Hushai worked to confuse and undermine Ahithophel's advice (2 Samuel 15:32–37; 17:1–14).

## 2 Samuel 15:32

- At this point in Israel's history, people worshiped God at multiple altars across the land. The tabernacle, which had been around since the time of Joshua and Samuel, no longer existed. The temple had not yet been built.
- An Arkite was possibly a non-Israelite from the region south of Bethel (Joshua 16:2).

### 2 Samuel 15:34

David believed God was guiding events, but he also made strategic moves to support his goals.

### 2 Samuel 16:1

- Ziba: See study note on 2 Samuel 9:11; also see 2 Samuel 9:1–13; 19:24–30.
- As Saul's grandson (2 Samuel 16:3), Mephibosheth was a potential rival for the throne.

### 2 Samuel 16:3–4

Ziba was lying to David for his own benefit. Later, Mephibosheth told the truth about what happened (2 Samuel 19:24–30).

### 2 Samuel 16:5

Bahurim was in the territory of Benjamin, east of the Mount of Olives, on the road to the Jordan River. Many people from Benjamin, the tribe of Saul, likely still felt resentment toward David's rule. In Shimei's case, this loyalty to Saul was even stronger because Shimei belonged to Saul's own clan within the tribe of Benjamin.

### 2 Samuel 16:7–8

Shimei cursed David. He blamed David for the violent deaths of Saul and members of Saul's family.

### 2 Samuel 16:8

The LORD has paid you back: Shimei thought Absalom's rebellion was the Lord punishing David. However, David was innocent (see study notes on 2 Samuel 1:4, 15–16).

### 2 Samuel 16:9

Abishai was David's nephew (1 Chronicles 2:13–16) and likely part of his personal guard. He thought no one should speak to the king disrespectfully and survive (compare 2 Samuel 19:21). David was more cautious in making judgments (compare 1 Kings 2:8–9).

### 2 Samuel 16:10

- If he curses me because the LORD told him: David thought it might be punishment for past sins.
- David was actually reducing the violence around him, despite Shimei's accusations.

### 2 Samuel 16:11–12

How much more: David understood why someone who supported Saul might hate him.

### 2 Samuel 16:16

Long live the king!: Hushai's words were intentionally unclear. He was actually serving the true king, David, who was truly "the one chosen by the LORD" (2 Samuel 16:18). Hushai avoided mentioning the king's name, making Absalom think Hushai was loyal to him instead of David.

### 2 Samuel 16:19

whom should I serve: (literally and second, to whom will I do service? Not before his son?): The unclear language continues. Hushai expressed his loyalty as a question, not a promise. He intended to serve David while tricking Absalom into believing he had switched sides. Similarly, As I served in your father's presence, so also I will serve in yours literally means, as I served before your father, so I will [serve your father] before you.

### 2 Samuel 16:21

Sleep with your father's concubines: A usurper (someone who takes power by force) would take a previous ruler's harem to strengthen his claim to the throne (see 2 Samuel 3:7). Absalom's action violated Deuteronomy 22:30.

### 2 Samuel 16:22

Absalom wanted to show the people he had taken the throne and its royal powers. His disgraceful act mirrored David's affair with Bathsheba, which also started on that roof (2 Samuel 11:2–4). This event fulfilled Nathan's prophecy (2 Samuel 12:11–12).

### 2 Samuel 16:23

was like the consultation of the word of God: Compare with 2 Samuel 17:14.

### 2 Samuel 17:1–14

Ahithophel advised a quick surprise attack against David with a small force of 12,000 men (2 Samuel 17:1). This plan would give David no time to prepare or organize a defense.

David's double agent, Hushai, gave different advice. He urged Absalom to wait and gather the entire army of Israel before attacking (2 Samuel 17:11). This plan promised a much larger force and would prevent David from using guerrilla tactics (small surprise attacks).

Because the Lord was working against Absalom, he rejected Ahithophel's good advice and accepted Hushai's poor advice (2 Samuel 17:14; compare 1 Kings 12:1–15).

### 2 Samuel 17:3

as a bride ... You seek: The Hebrew text suggests that everyone's loyalty depends on David's death. The Greek version shows a young wife returning to her husband after a brief argument.

### 2 Samuel 17:11

The nationwide military draft from Dan to Beersheba (the northern and southern limits of Israel) aimed to create a much stronger army.

### 2 Samuel 17:14

- Ahithophel's strategy was the stronger military plan. However, Hushai had a psychological and rhetorical advantage (he understood how to persuade Absalom). He also carried out the Lord's purpose. Because of this, Hushai gained Absalom's favor.
- the LORD had purposed to thwart: Although Absalom made early gains, his attempt to take the throne was doomed from the beginning.

### 2 Samuel 17:17

- Jonathan and Ahimaaz: See 2 Samuel 15:27, 36.
- The location of En-rogel is uncertain, but it cannot have been too far east of Jerusalem.

### 2 Samuel 17:18–20

Bahurim was where Shimei, a supporter of Saul from the tribe of Benjamin, lived (2 Samuel 16:5; 19:16). Shimei's cursing of David at Bahurim showed David's decline. In contrast, the escape of Ahimaaz and Jonathan showed hope for David's return to power.

### 2 Samuel 17:23

hanged himself: Ahithophel saw that David would win and Absalom would fail. He chose to take his own life instead of facing David.

### 2 Samuel 17:24

Mahanaim was once the capital city of Ish-bosheth and Abner (2 Samuel 2:8, 12, 29). It later became the base from which David ruled.

### 2 Samuel 17:25

According to 1 Chronicles 2:15–16, Abigail and Zeruiah were David's sisters. However, since Abigail is called the daughter of Nahash, they were likely David's half-sisters. Nahash was probably their father, and his widow may have married Jesse, who then had David and his brothers.

### 2 Samuel 17:27

- Shobi was probably the brother of Hanun, who had humiliated David's messengers after the death of Nahash (2 Samuel 10; see study note on 2 Samuel 10:1–5).
- Makir was Mephibosheth's host before David summoned him (2 Samuel 9:4–5).
- Barzillai of Gilead was probably not the same as Barzillai from Meholah (2 Samuel 21:8).

### 2 Samuel 18:3

you are worth ten thousand of us: David's men praised him, but their request for him to stay behind might actually suggest that David was becoming weaker (see 2 Samuel 21:15–17).

### 2 Samuel 18:5

Joab disobeyed David's order to be gentle with young Absalom (2 Samuel 18:11–15). This was the second time Joab killed someone against David's wishes (see 2 Samuel 3:22–37).

### 2 Samuel 18:6

The forest of Ephraim was an area east of the Jordan settled by the tribe of Ephraim.

### 2 Samuel 18:8

the forest devoured more people: The land in the forest (its rough ground and thick growth) removed the numerical advantage of Absalom's army.

### 2 Samuel 18:9

Absalom, who was very proud of his hair, died because of it. He had set up for himself a pillar (2 Samuel 18:18), but after his death, he was thrown into a pit (2 Samuel 18:17) and did not receive a proper burial. These contrasts highlight the difference between Absalom's goals and his final outcome.

### 2 Samuel 18:11

A hero's belt might have been a sword belt that honored a soldier for bravery and courage in battle (compare 1 Samuel 18:4).

### 2 Samuel 18:14

thrust them through the heart of Absalom: Earlier, Joab acted as a peacemaker between David and Absalom (2 Samuel 14). Joab might have thought letting Absalom live would cause more problems for David and himself. (Absalom had chosen Amasa, Joab's first

cousin, to take Joab's place as the commander of Israel's army; see 2 Samuel 17:25.)

### 2 Samuel 18:15

surrounded ... and killed him: Perhaps Joab ordered his armor bearers to kill Absalom. In this way, Joab could later argue to David that he himself did not kill Absalom.

### 2 Samuel 18:17

all the Israelites fled, each to his home: Those who supported Absalom knew their lives were in danger (2 Samuel 17:11; compare 2 Samuel 19:8). They had supported a usurper (a person who tried to take the throne by force), and his attempt to seize the kingdom had failed.

### 2 Samuel 18:18

- I have no son: See study note on 2 Samuel 14:27. Because Absalom had no heir to continue his family line, he hoped a monument would keep his name and memory alive.
- to this day: The narrator was probably writing during the reign of Solomon. The location of the monument is now unknown.

### 2 Samuel 18:19

Zadok: See study note on 2 Samuel 15:24.

### 2 Samuel 18:21

A Cushite: Joab decided it was safer to send a foreigner to inform the king about Absalom's death. If David reacted badly, losing a foreigner was less significant than losing a priest's son.

### 2 Samuel 18:25

If he is alone ... he bears good news: A runner traveling alone was usually a messenger who carried official news.

### 2 Samuel 18:28–29

All is well! (Hebrew shalom [peace, safety, well-being]): David then asked, "Is the young man Ab-shalom shalom? (That is, "What about young Absalom? Is he all right?") Even though Absalom had opposed him, he was still David's son. David cared more about his son's fate than about the well-being of the soldiers who had fought for him (2 Samuel 19:5–6).

### 2 Samuel 18:33

David was not afraid to show his emotions openly, whether filled with great joy (2 Samuel 6:14–19) or deep sadness. His feelings for Absalom were genuine, not fake.

### 2 Samuel 19:5–7

These verses record the only time that Joab openly corrected David (compare 2 Samuel 24:3).

### 2 Samuel 19:9–10

The argument among the tribes of Israel (possibly only the northern tribes) led them to agree that they should ask David to return as king. They may have preferred this option instead of returning to a time of weak shared leadership (the period of the judges; see 2 Samuel 20:1).

### 2 Samuel 19:11–12

When David saw that the northern tribes would accept him (2 Samuel 19:9–10), he sent messengers to encourage Judah, his own people, to accept him too. See also study note on 2 Samuel 19:41–43.

### 2 Samuel 19:13

Commander ... in place of Joab: Amasa did not hold this position for long (see 2 Samuel 20:7–10).

### 2 Samuel 19:15

Gilgal was an important city during the time of Samuel and Saul (see study note on 2 Samuel 19:40; 1 Samuel 7:16; 11:15).

### 2 Samuel 19:15–23

When David returned to Jerusalem, he forgave Shimei. Shimei was a supporter of Saul who had cursed David during his escape (see 2 Samuel 16:5–14). However, Shimei's actions were eventually punished (1 Kings 2:8, 36–46).

### 2 Samuel 19:17

Ziba: See 2 Samuel 16:1–4.

### 2 Samuel 19:20

- your servant knows that I have sinned: Shimei might have truly repented, or he might have been trying to save his life. David's concern for Absalom's safety showed he was not the ruthless throne-stealer Shimei thought. Absalom did not replace David (2 Samuel 16:8), as Shimei claimed.

- all the house of Joseph: Just as Jacob's name could represent all Israel (for example, Numbers 24:19; Isaiah 10:20), Joseph's name could represent all the northern tribes (see study notes on Amos 5:6; Zechariah 10:6).

## 2 Samuel 19:21–22

- Compare 2 Samuel 16:9–12.
- Abishai: See study note on 2 Samuel 16:9.
- Sons of Zeruiah: See study notes on 2 Samuel 2:18; 17:25. Abishai often wanted to kill those against David (compare 2 Samuel 16:9; 1 Samuel 26:8). David was also frustrated with Joab, Abishai's brother (see 2 Samuel 3:28–29, 39; 19:13; 1 Kings 2:5–6).

## 2 Samuel 19:23

David's oath of protection was not binding on David's heir, Solomon, who later ordered Shimei's execution for far less serious crimes (1 Kings 2:36–46).

## 2 Samuel 19:24

Mephibosheth did not care for his appearance while David was away from Jerusalem. This lack of grooming was a sign of mourning and showed his loyalty to David. If Mephibosheth had planned to claim the throne (2 Samuel 16:3), he would not have kept such an unkempt appearance.

## 2 Samuel 19:24–30

See 2 Samuel 16:1–4.

## 2 Samuel 19:27–28

- like the angel of God: See study note on 2 Samuel 14:17.
- deserves death … What further right, then, do I have to keep appealing?: If Mephibosheth had wanted to betray David, it would have shown deep ingratitude for all David had done for him.

## 2 Samuel 19:30

Mephibosheth's lack of interest in claiming half of his property clearly showed his true happiness about David's return.

## 2 Samuel 19:31

Gilead was part of Manasseh's territory on the east side of the Jordan (Joshua 17:5).

## 2 Samuel 19:31–40

Barzillai was old and weak, so he turned down David's invitation to the royal court in Jerusalem. This invitation was a reward for Barzillai's help. Instead, David took Barzillai's son Kimham (see also 1 Kings 2:7).

## 2 Samuel 19:39

kissed Barzillai: This kiss was sincere and showed real affection. It contrasts with David's cold kiss for Absalom (2 Samuel 14:33) and with Absalom's planned kiss to win the people's favor (2 Samuel 15:5).

## 2 Samuel 19:40

Gilgal, a natural stop along David's westward route, was also a politically significant location: It was where the people had proclaimed Saul king (1 Samuel 11:15) and where Samuel later announced Saul's reign would end (1 Samuel 13:13–15). David's kingship now had a new beginning at Gilgal.

## 2 Samuel 19:41–43

- This disagreement started because David favored his own tribe, Judah. It shows the early signs of the split that eventually divided Judah and Israel into two nations (1 Kings 11:31; 12:16, 20).
- Were we not the first: See 2 Samuel 19:11–12.

## 2 Samuel 20:1

We have no share in David: The northern Israelites used this same rallying cry to break away from Solomon (1 Kings 12:16). Sheba's failed revolt hinted at the eventual downfall of the northern kingdom, which began with a similar revolt by Jeroboam (1 Kings 12).

## 2 Samuel 20:3

The ten concubines (2 Samuel 15:16) whom Absalom had publicly mistreated (16:21–22) faced a fate similar to Michal's (see 6:23 and 2 Samuel 6:23).

## 2 Samuel 20:4–5

The king made Amasa the new commander of the armies, replacing Joab (2 Samuel 19:13–14). David expected Amasa to be as efficient and effective as Joab.

## 2 Samuel 20:7

the Cherethites, the Pelethites: See study note on 2 Samuel 8:18.

## 2 Samuel 20:9

to kiss him: This was a common greeting that showed respect and warmth. However, such greetings were not always sincere (compare 2 Samuel 14:33).

## 2 Samuel 20:10

Amasa ... died: This was the second time Joab killed an enemy commander through deceit. The first was Abner (2 Samuel 3:26–27). David tried twice to unite enemy groups by including the enemy's military leader (2 Samuel 3:6–13; 17:25; 19:13). Both times, Joab ruined David's plans by deceitfully murdering the rival commander (2 Samuel 3:22–30).

## 2 Samuel 20:14

Abel-beth-maacah was in the northernmost region of Israelite territory, 6.4 kilometers (4 miles) west of Dan.

## 2 Samuel 20:15

A siege ramp was usually a dirt ramp constructed against a wall. It was a common method to break through a city's defenses (see also 2 Kings 25:1; Jeremiah 52:4).

## 2 Samuel 20:16

wise woman: Compare 2 Samuel 14:2.

## 2 Samuel 20:18–19

- The woman shared a saying to persuade Joab not to destroy the entire city, especially a noble one like Abel (short for Abel-beth-maacah, 2 Samuel 20:15), just to catch one criminal.
- a city that is a mother in Israel: It was common to refer to outlying villages around a larger city as its "daughters."

## 2 Samuel 20:23

In 2 Samuel 8:16, Joab was said to be "over the army," but here he is the commander of Israel's army. David gained full control of Israel after defeating the northern rebel groups.

## 2 Samuel 20:23–26

This list of David's leaders and the similar list in 2 Samuel 8:15–18 marks the beginning and end of chapters 9–20 in David's life. Even after the major crises described in these 12 chapters, David's rule did not collapse. He still had a complete and functioning administration.

## 2 Samuel 20:24

Adoram: The officer in charge of forced labor (not mentioned in 2 Samuel:15–18; see also 1 Kings 4:6). This indicates that David now controlled Israel enough to collect taxes and slave labor across the kingdom (compare 1 Samuel 8:11–17).

## 2 Samuel 20:25

Unlike David's personal priest (see 2 Samuel 8:18; 20:26 and corresponding notes), Zadok and Abiathar led public worship.

## 2 Samuel 20:26

David's personal priest was probably not a Levite but rather a special class of religious servant appointed for his royal court (see study note on 2 Samuel 8:18).

## 2 Samuel 21:1

- sought the face of the Lord: The Hebrew verb here is the same as when David "begged" for Bathsheba's child's life (2 Samuel 12:16). In these cases, "seeking" was done in a moment of crisis. However, in the Old Testament, "seeking God" usually means daily devotion and obedience to God (for example, Psalms 40:16; 105:4; Proverbs 28:5).
- the blood shed by Saul and his family: The famine happened because they broke an oath made before the Lord (Joshua 9:19–20).
- he killed the Gibeonites: This event is not recorded elsewhere. Unlawful bloodshed polluted the land, making it bleak and unproductive (compare Genesis 4:10–12; Numbers 35:30–34).

## 2 Samuel 21:1–24.25

The final chapters of 2 Samuel form a coda (a concluding section). This section brings together and summarizes the main themes from earlier chapters.

These chapters are thematic, not chronological (arranged by topic, not by time). Because of this, not all the events happened at the end of David's reign (for example, 2 Samuel 22:1).

The material is arranged using a common Hebrew literary pattern called a chiasm (a mirror-like structure). In a chiasm, the first and last sections match, and the middle section is the focus.

The structure of this chiasm is as follows:

- A: Saul's sin against the Gibeonites and the punishment that affected the whole community (2 Samuel 21:1–14)
- B: David's warriors and their heroic deeds (2 Samuel 21:15–22)
- C: David's Psalm (2 Samuel 22:1–51)
- C′: David's Psalm (2 Samuel 23:1–7)
- B′: David's warriors and their heroic deeds (2 Samuel 23:8–39)

- A′: David's sin involving the census and the punishment that affected the whole community (2 Samuel 24:1–25)

A chiasm draws attention to the center section. Here, the center is David's hymns. These hymns do not focus on David himself. Instead, they focus on David's God.

## 2 Samuel 21:2

- Though the Amorites were a specific group of people (Genesis 10:16), here it refers to the people living in Canaan before the Israelites.
- When zeal (strong devotion or passion) is directed in the right way, it is commendable. The Bible gives positive examples of this kind of zeal (Numbers 25:11; 1 Kings 19:10). Saul's zeal, however, was misdirected. He showed clear disregard for Israel's covenant (a binding agreement) with the Gibeonites.

## 2 Samuel 21:3

Saul's actions had caused the Gibeonites to curse Israel (compare Romans 2:24). After David made things right with the Gibeonites, the Gibeonites would bless the Lord's people again.

## 2 Samuel 21:6

- seven of his male descendants: The law codes of other ancient Near Eastern nations sometimes permitted members of a family to be punished for crimes a guilty individual had committed. But Deuteronomy 24:16 did not allow this practice among the Israelites. Only God could impose such penalties (Deuteronomy 5:9).

The few instances in the Bible when offspring were punished were not regular criminal cases. Instead, they involved offenses against God, such as violation of the kherem (a ban on goods in wars of total destruction ordered by God; Joshua 7:24–25) or of national oaths (as here).

- At Gibeah of Saul, the chosen of the LORD: This probably refers to the high place at Gibeon, which Solomon later visited (1 Kings 3:3–4; 2 Chronicles 1:3). If the Hebrew reading is correct, , the Gibeonites were likely speaking with irony (using words to mock rather than praise). They may have been calling Saul "the chosen of the Lord" in a sarcastic way.

## 2 Samuel 21:7

the oath: See 1 Samuel 20:14–15. Unlike Saul, David kept his promise even as he faced the dangerous consequences of Saul breaking an oath.

## 2 Samuel 21:8

- Armoni and Mephibosheth were Saul's only two remaining sons.
- Merab daughter of Saul: Ancient manuscripts differ on the name of Saul's daughter. The Hebrew text names Michal, but the Greek text names Merab. Many translations, including the Berean Standard Bible, follow the Greek reading. This is because Michal remained childless for the rest of her life (2 Samuel 6:22–23). Merab, not Michal, was married to Adriel (1 Samuel 18:19). Michal's later husband was Palti (2 Samuel 3:15).
- Barzillai from Meholah (compare 1 Samuel 18:19) should not be confused with Barzillai of Gilead (2 Samuel 19:31).

## 2 Samuel 21:9

- The barley harvest began in **the spring**, usually in April.
- before the LORD means "before the Lord's altar" (see study note on 2 Samuel 21:6).

## 2 Samuel 21:10

The Gibeonites were not Israelites (2 Samuel 21:2), so they did not follow the Israelite law in Deuteronomy 21:22–23 about quickly and properly burying a criminal. Rizpah wanted to prevent her sons from being further shamed after their death.

## 2 Samuel 21:11–13

Rizpah's action shamed David into likewise honoring the dead of Saul's family.

## 2 Samuel 21:14

- We do not know the exact location of Zela.
- prayers for the land: This refers to the famine described earlier in the story in 2 Samuel 21:1–2.

## 2 Samuel 21:15

Describing David as weak and tired shifts the focus from his skills and achievements to God as the reason for his success (2 Samuel 22).

## 2 Samuel 21:15–22

The longer account of battles with the Philistines highlights important victories by David's mighty warriors. A similar list of their deeds appears later in the chapter (see also 2 Samuel 23:8–39).

## 2 Samuel 21:16

a descendant of Rapha: Compare Genesis 14:5; Deuteronomy 2:10–11, 20–21; 3:11.

## 2 Samuel 21:17

- Abishai was a skilled warrior and very loyal to David, whom he bravely saved (see "Abishai" Profile).
- the lamp of Israel: Compare 2 Samuel 18:3. Both passages show the deep admiration David's men had for him.

## 2 Samuel 21:18

The location of Gob is uncertain.

## 2 Samuel 21:19

Some traditions identify Elhanan as David. This view is mainly based on two points. Elhanan was from Bethlehem, and David is described elsewhere as the one who killed Goliath (1 Samuel 17:48–51). However, a different explanation is more likely. The words brother of were probably left out of the Masoretic Text by a scribal error (a copying mistake). This would explain why Elhanan appears to be described as killing Goliath in another passage.

## 2 Samuel 22:1–51

This prayer of thanksgiving (also recorded in Psalm 18) appears near the end of David's story. But David likely prayed it much earlier in his life. This prayer and Hannah's prayer in 1 Samuel 2:1–10 together enclose the book of Samuel with an inclusio (literary bookends). Hannah was saved from being unable to have children, and David was saved from his enemies.

The hymn's placement also provides a parallel to Moses. Both Moses and David's stories end with a song praising God (see also Deuteronomy 31:30–32:43). Both emphasize God as a "Rock" (Deuteronomy 32:4, 15, 18, 30, 31; 2 Samuel 22:2, 3, 32, 47). Both are followed by second and shorter poetic pieces:

- the final blessing of Moses to the Israelite tribes (Deuteronomy 33), and
- David's last words (2 Samuel 23:1–7).

## 2 Samuel 22:2

- Hannah said, there is no Rock like our God (1 Samuel 2:2). David also called the Lord his rock, remembering how God saved him from Saul at the Rock of Escape (1 Samuel 23:28). The Hebrew word for "rock" in 2 Samuel 22:3 (different from 22:2) is used in 1 Samuel 24:2 to describe the Rocks of the Wild Goats, where Saul thought David was hiding.
- fortress: This word also referred to David's physical stronghold (1 Samuel 22:4), where he and his men hid from Saul.

## 2 Samuel 22:3

The phrase the horn of my salvation is similar to Hannah's words the LORD in whom my horn is exalted (1 Samuel 2:1).

## 2 Samuel 22:7

Sanctuary sometimes refers to the tabernacle or the temple. However, in this context, His temple means God's heavenly home. The tabernacle and temple did not exist at this time.

## 2 Samuel 22:8–20

David clearly explains how God listened to him (2 Samuel 22:7). He describes God's rescue as a theophany (a visible sign of God's presence; see study notes on Exodus 19:16–25; Deuteronomy 1:33), which reminds us of God's appearance at Mount Sinai (Exodus 19:16–20; compare Judges 5:4–5).

## 2 Samuel 22:14

The LORD thundered from heaven: See 1 Samuel 2:10.

## 2 Samuel 22:21–30

David's rescue and success were linked to his obedience to God. God rewards those who live in a way that pleases him (see also Leviticus 26:1–13; Deuteronomy 28:1–14; Psalm 1).

## 2 Samuel 22:22–24

David wrote these words long before his sin with Bathsheba (2 Samuel 22:1). His statement about being blameless does not mean he was perfect. He was just saying he had kept the covenant and followed its law.

## 2 Samuel 22:31–51

David praises God for saving him in the past and for promising blessings to his family in the future (see 2 Samuel 7:8–16).

## 2 Samuel 22:32

See Isaiah 43:11; 44:6, 8; 45:5, 21.

## 2 Samuel 22:34

David likely saw deer while he hid in the hills and caves for many days (1 Samuel 19:11–27:12).

## 2 Samuel 22:38–40

Before David became king, he achieved impressive military victories (see 1 Samuel 17:12–58; 18:17–30; 23:1–5; 30:1–31). Instead of boasting, David praised God and credited him for the success.

## 2 Samuel 22:51

Compare 2 Samuel 7:5–29; 1 Samuel 2:10.

## 2 Samuel 23:1

- David's last words were not necessarily his final spoken words (see 1 Kings 1:16, 29–30, 33–35; 2:1–9). They were his last public act of worship to God as king (compare 1 Samuel 12:1–25).
- The oracle of David: The language shows he was about to deliver an oracle, a message from God (2 Samuel 23:2).
- the sweet psalmist of Israel: For other mentions of David as a musician and poet, see 1 Chronicles 23:5; 2 Chronicles 29:26, 27; Nehemiah 12:36; Amos 6:5.

## 2 Samuel 23:1–7

This passage comes from the end of David's career and reflects on his experience as king, even as 2 Samuel 22 reflects on his experience before becoming king.

## 2 Samuel 23:2

The Spirit of the LORD spoke through me: David spoke of God, and in the process, God spoke through David.

## 2 Samuel 23:5

my house ... everlasting covenant: David is referring to the prophecy Nathan made about David and his descendants (2 Samuel 7:12–16). Jesus is the everlasting king who is the "son of David" (Matthew 1:1).

## 2 Samuel 23:6

Compare Psalm 1:4–5.

## 2 Samuel 23:8–39

- This section lists David's top warriors by name, highlighting their notable achievements. These warriors were like "iron tools" that God used to defeat the godless (2 Samuel 23:7).
- The list is divided into the Three and the Thirty. Some Hebrew scholars suggest that the Thirty could mean "Officers." If true, the Three might have originally referred to a specific military role.

## 2 Samuel 23:10

to plunder: Compare 1 Samuel 30:9–10, 21–25.

## 2 Samuel 23:13

- The cave of Adullam was where David hid from Saul (see 1 Samuel 22:1).
- The valley of Rephaim was located between Bethlehem and Jerusalem (see 2 Samuel 5:17–25).

## 2 Samuel 23:15–16

- longed ... and said: This Hebrew verb often means strong desire (see Numbers 11:4, had a strong craving; Psalm 106:14, craved intensely). It is unclear whether David's craving for water was excessive, but it did lead to risky actions.
- well near the gate: David had memories from his younger days of growing up in Bethlehem. The location of the well is unknown.

## 2 Samuel 23:17

Is this not the blood of the men: When David poured the water onto the ground, this action did not show ingratitude. Instead, the water had been brought back at the risk of the warriors' lives. David treated the water as equal to their blood. In this way, the water represented life itself, which belongs to God alone and must not be consumed by humans (Leviticus 17:10–13; Deuteronomy 12:23–24).

## 2 Samuel 23:18–23

- Here are examples of the skills of Abishai and Benaiah. Abishai was very aggressive toward David's enemies, especially Saul (1 Samuel 26:6–9) and Saul's relative Shimei (2 Samuel 16:9–11). Abishai saved David's life during a Philistine war (2 Samuel 21:16–17).
- Benaiah first appeared as the commander of the mercenaries who were David's bodyguards. These men were separate from the regular army (2 Samuel 8:18; 20:23). He also led a 24,000-man division of the regular army that served the king every third month (1 Chronicles 27:5–6). He played a key role in Solomon's rise to the throne (1 Kings 1:32–49) and became the commander of Solomon's army, like Joab was for David.

## 2 Samuel 23:24

- Asahel was David's nephew. Abner killed him during the war between David and Ish-bosheth (2 Samuel 2:18–32). Asahel's inclusion suggests that some of these lists date from the early years of David's rule.

- Elhanan son of Dodo should not be confused with Elhanan son of Jair (2 Samuel 21:19; 1 Chronicles 20:5).

## 2 Samuel 23:39

- The very last name mentioned is Uriah the Hittite. There is an earlier reference to his father-in-law, Eliam, father of Bathsheba (2 Samuel 23:34; see 11:3). The writer of Chronicles never mentioned David's sins against Bathsheba and Uriah. The author of 2 Samuel not only described the sins but also emphasized Uriah's name by placing it at the end of the list (1 Chronicles 11:10–47). Uriah was not an ordinary soldier. He was a loyal member of David's elite guard. This makes David's betrayal of him even more serious.
- There were thirty-seven in all: Only thirty-six names appear, assuming:
- "Shammah ... from Harar" (2 Samuel 23:11) is different from "Shammah from Harod" (2 Samuel 23:25), and
- "Benaiah son of Jehoiada" (2 Samuel 23:20) is different from "Benaiah from Pirathon" (2 Samuel 23:30)

The thirty-seventh warrior might be Joab. He is mentioned only briefly (2 Samuel 23:18, 37) and is missing from the list of names. Many believe he is excluded because he was David's chief military leader and did not need to be added. The omission might also reflect David's complicated relationship with Joab, who was executed when Solomon followed David's last wishes (1 Kings 2:5–6, 28–34).

## 2 Samuel 24:1

- The reason for God's anger against Israel is unclear (but see Deuteronomy 4:25; 6:14–15; 29:22–28; 31:16–18).
- The phrase stirred up refers to a Hebrew verb (suth) that means enticing or inciting someone to do wrong (1 Samuel 26:19, stirred you up against me). People usually disliked census-taking because they saw it as an invasion of privacy. They thought it led to taxes or forced military service (see study note on 2 Samuel 24:9). If David acted out of pride or was planning an unjust war (as 2 Samuel 24:9 might suggest), this could explain why it was considered a sin for him (2 Samuel 24:10).

## 2 Samuel 24:2

Dan and Beersheba were the traditional northern and southern boundaries of Israel. This phrase meant the entire land of Israel.

## 2 Samuel 24:3

why does my lord ... want to do such a thing?: Joab either realized that such a move would be unpopular among the people, or he believed that it was wrong before God.

## 2 Samuel 24:9

The phrase men of valor indicates that the census mainly counted those eligible for military service. The total for Judah here might be rounded up from the number in 1 Chronicles 21:5. The different number for Israel in 1 Chronicles 21:5 (1,100,000) might result from adding a regular standing army of 300,000 (not recorded elsewhere) to the 800,000 found through the census.

## 2 Samuel 24:10

I have sinned: See study note on 2 Samuel 24:1. David thought his sin caused the plague and that the removal of his sin would make things right (see also 2 Samuel 24:17). However, it is clear that Israel, not David, was the true object of God's wrath (2 Samuel 24:1).

## 2 Samuel 24:11

Gad, David's seer, is mentioned only here and in 1 Samuel 22:5. A seer is an early term for a prophet (1 Samuel 9:9, 19). Unlike pagan magicians or sorcerers, biblical seers had visions inspired by God (see also 2 Kings 17:13; Isaiah 29:10; 30:9–10; Amos 7:12; Micah 3:7) and served as God's messengers.

## 2 Samuel 24:13

David had already experienced the first two options. He had fled from Saul and later from Absalom. He had also lived through a famine caused by Saul's murder of the Gibeonites (2 Samuel 21:1).

At first, three days of severe plague may have seemed less frightening. However, the plague caused the deaths of 70,000 people (2 Samuel 24:15).

## 2 Samuel 24:16

- the LORD relented: God might stop his judgment:
- when someone else pleads for the person in trouble (Exodus 32:12–14),
- when the sinful person turns away from their wrongdoing (Jeremiah 18:8), or
- simply because God chooses to stop.

- the angel who was destroying the people: See Exodus 12:23.
- A threshing floor was an open area where people separated grain from the chaff. Gideon met God at a threshing floor (Judges 6:37). Araunah's threshing floor later became the location of the Temple (1 Chronicles 21:18–22:1; 2 Chronicles 3:1).
- Araunah the Jebusite: Although David captured Jerusalem from the Jebusites (2 Samuel 5:6–9), he did not completely remove them or drive them away.

## 2 Samuel 24:17

- I, the shepherd, have sinned: Earlier, David confessed his sin only about his situation ("take away the iniquity of Your servant," 2 Samuel 24:10). Now, he prayed for those he thought were innocent (but see 2 Samuel 24:1) and offered to die for them.
- these sheep: David was the shepherd (a leader who guided, protected, and cared for the people) of Israel (see study note on 2 Samuel 7:8).

## 2 Samuel 24:21

so that the plague: David did not know that God had already told the angel the plague would end (2 Samuel 24:16).

## 2 Samuel 24:25

David acted like a priest when he built an altar, offered burnt and peace offerings, and prayed for his people. In response, the Lord answered his prayer (see 2 Samuel 21:14).